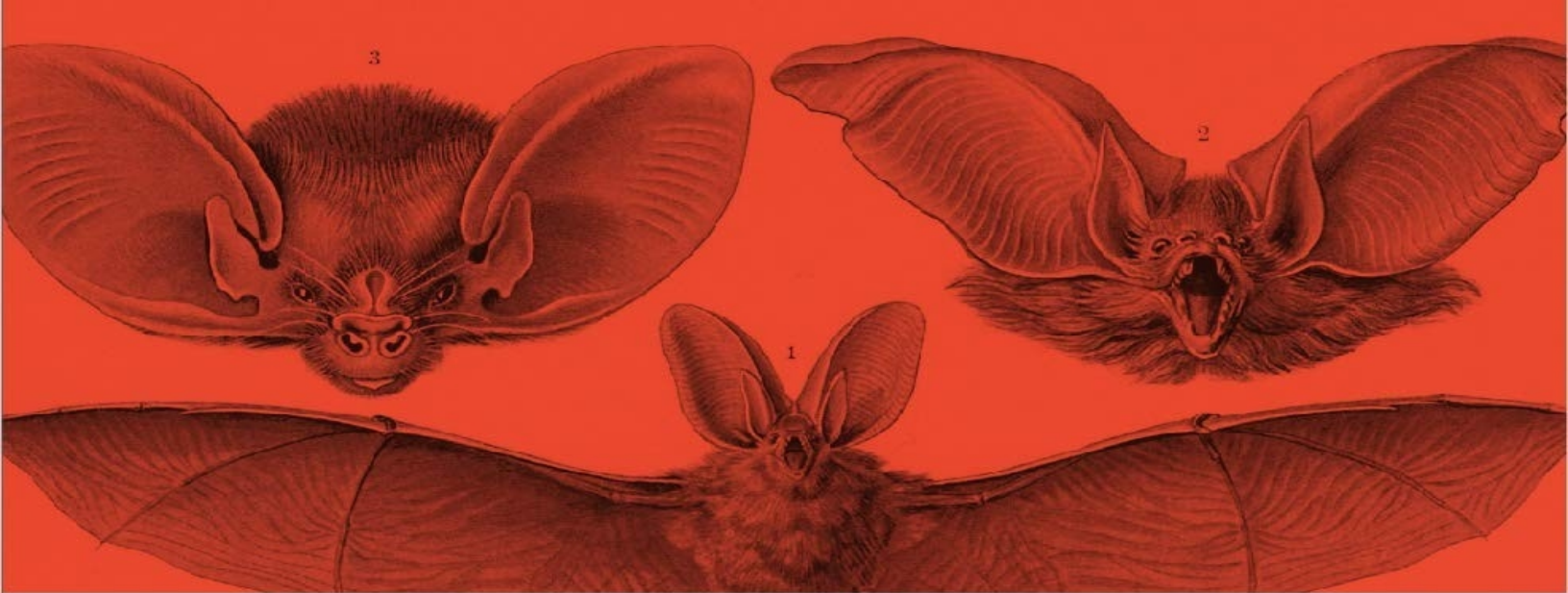




"I can't think of a better guide through this ethereal, infuriating book than Carmen Machado."

—Jordan Hall,
co-creator & writer
of *Carmilla: The Series*

Carmilla

JOSEPH SHERIDAN LE FANU

EDITED BY *Carmen Maria Machado*





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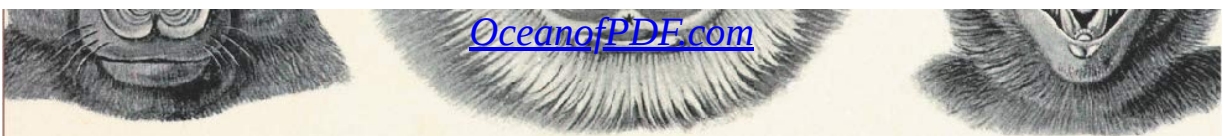
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Carmilla

J. Sheridan LeFanu


LANTERNFISH PRESS

Philadelphia, PA

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You Are Mine: Obsession, Odylic Influences, and LeFanu's *Carmilla*

When Joseph Sheridan LeFanu's magnum opus, *Carmilla*, was first published in installments in *The Dark Blue* in 1871, readers everywhere received it as fiction. When it later appeared in his collection of stories *In a Glass Darkly*, the other accounts of Doctor Hesselius were evaluated similarly. Each new edition, adaptation, and reimagination of *Carmilla* has treated the correspondence between Doctor Hesselius and Laura as fictional artifact, an epistolary fabrication nested in layers of metacommentary like a set of Russian nesting dolls.

It was not until 1973 that a scholar from the University of Iowa, Dr. Jane Leight, revealed the full dimensions of this literary mystery during a research trip to Ireland. Nestled behind a hollow wall in LeFanu's erstwhile study, she discovered a stack of correspondence between two individuals: an unnamed doctor and a woman who called herself only *V*. Accompanying these letters was the infamous introduction to *Carmilla*, penned in LeFanu's hand. This was not the original—rather, “original”—manuscript that resided in the University of Leeds's Special Collection; rather, it suggested that the narrative artifice literary scholars had been admiring for well over a century was not artifice at all.

Within a few years' time, Dr. Leight would come to believe that "Martin Hesselius" and "Laura" were in fact pseudonyms for two quite real historical figures: Doctor Peter Fontenot and Veronika Hausle. (Her research to uncover the true identities of the letter writers was extraordinarily thorough, and has been artfully covered in great detail in Lucia Trecht's *The Professor and the Vampire* .)ⁱ

Doctor Peter Fontenot was the son of a Cajun haberdasher and a British railroad heiress. Though he had practiced medicine for many years, his second career as a kind of occult detective began in the early 1850s, when he moved to London to settle his late mother's affairs. In addition to his roles as doctor and collector of supernatural stories, he was also an amateur alchemist, and he was a contemporary of both Baron Vordenburg and a young Professor Abraham Van Helsing (another "character" whose real-life counterpart had his life's work undermined by the guise of fiction).ⁱⁱ Veronika Hausle (née Archer) was the daughter of an English soldier and a minor Hungarian noblewoman,ⁱⁱⁱ best known not for her tangle with "Carmilla" but her advocacy for women's agency in the realms of faith and medicine before her death in 1870.

And what of the identity of the eponymous Carmilla? According to Dr. Leight, Carmilla was, in fact, Marcia Marén, a young Spanish-Cuban aristocrat whose father sent her to Europe with her nursemaid and an eccentric governess during the beginning of the tensions that would eventually boil over into the Ten Years' War. This is all to say, just as Carmilla mercilessly pierced the breast of the young Laura, so LeFanu drank of what was not his.

To say that Laura—that is, Veronika—is a profoundly moving narrator is an understatement; she is by turns clever, vulnerable, awestruck, funny. Her loneliness is raw, her nascent desires familiar to any sexual creature. She is also, not unlike Nabokov's *Lolita*, dead before the story begins; *Carmilla* is her coffin^{iv} and headstone both.

It would be no surprise if the reader inferred, from the story, that Veronika's offstage death was a result of the long and terrible ordeal she suffered at the hands of the vampiress Marcia. Yet nothing could be further from the truth: Married off to a Romanian viscount a few years later, Veronika died in childbirth, her fingers curled around the branch of a wild rose.^v An extraordinary life, an unextraordinary death.

Perhaps one of the most arresting moments in *Carmilla* occurs just before the titular vampiress's arrival. Upon returning from an evening walk with her father, Laura encounters her two governesses tittering like schoolgirls beneath the celestial splendor of a full moon. One of them—Mademoiselle De Lafontaine—relates the tale of her cousin, a sailor on a merchant ship, who once fell asleep beneath such a moon. He had awoken, she claimed, “after a dream of an old woman clawing him by the cheek with his features horribly drawn to one side; his countenance had never quite recovered its equilibrium.” She speaks, then, of the “odylic and magnetic influence” of the night and the moon.

The concept of odic forces—the pseudoscientific philosophy of a pervading, electromagnetic life force in all things—was very much in vogue in the mid-nineteenth century.^{vi} While Veronika never espoused or studied odology, she did adapt her governess's dogma in a very specific way: she believed that, in her dreams, she shared a physical space with certain other dreamers: fellow citizens of a shared “dream-city.” It is believed by Lucia Trect and other scholars that this accounted for her instant and profound love for Marcia. That is to say, she believed that even before they met, they had occupied the same dream-city; and she believed that such a thing was as close to fate or destiny as you could come.

To contemporary eyes, it is impossible to argue with the queer currents that run beneath *Carmilla*'s text.^{vii} The imposition of contemporary

sexual understanding onto historical figures remains a sticking point for queer theorists and historians the world over, but there is far less ambiguity in the case of this particular text than one might think. There are, in fact, extant letters that did not make their way into LeFanu's final story. And while LeFanu says in his introduction that the now-dead Laura could not possibly have given more detail in her account, in fact she gave *so much more* detail that this statement, which might have once read as complimentary, seems to curdle into cruelty.

In her letters to Doctor Fontenot, Veronika wrote specifically of her own desire, not the mix of attraction and repulsion that LeFanu repeats over and over. She spoke not of the fear of Carmilla's return but of a profound desire for it. In contrast to the final beats of LeFanu's novella, she wrote in her original letters of awaking from daydreams thinking that she heard Marcia's footsteps outside the door. "I long for the door to open. I long to feel her run along my skin like so much smoke. I long for her to take me to the place where she went at night; together, we would not be lonely anymore." In another excised section of the correspondence, she described Marcia as "sunlight personified. She warmed me where I had only ever been cold; she took what was fallow and made it fruitful. I did not know that it was possible. I did not realize my soil was not salted." She spoke of the physicality of arousal—not as metaphor, but as fact—and the tender way the lovers consummated their relationship. "My heart beat faster, my breathing rose and fell rapidly; then a sobbing, that rose into a sense of strangulation and turned into a dreadful convulsion," she wrote. ^{viii} Later: "I descended the valley of her, over and over, until neither of us could locate our breath." And though she did not witness the execution of her beloved, she dreamt of it. "The road that curves through the mist of my dreams is lined with [Marcia's] body, beheaded," she wrote to Doctor Fontenot just before Christmas 1869. "Sometimes her corpse is limp as a doll, as you might expect, but sometimes a cry issues from the opened throat: *You are mine, you are mine, you are mine*. How I

fear that sound: that it might be true, and that it might never be true again.”

Once Veronika’s excised letters are restored to the record, the dimensions of the story become clearer: a young woman’s sexual awakening; the senseless slaughter of her supposed defiler. The ecclesiastics and doctors and fathers and uncles and barons and vampire hunters look less like well-intentioned protectors against a supernatural evil; their own accounts become highly suspect.

This is not to say that Veronika was without her doubts, or Marcia without her wickedness. (The latter’s seduction of the general’s niece is also part of the record, as is his niece’s subsequent suicide.) Her tendency towards obsession, her single-minded approach to sex, and her worldliness are easy to infer from Veronika’s accounts, and it is easy to see how these might have been at profound odds with Veronika’s well-being. Yet Marcia also may have been innocent of the more devious charges laid against her. It seems as though Marcia/Carmilla falls somewhere in the historical record alongside Countess Elizabeth Báthory de Ecsed, the Hungarian noblewoman accused of slaughtering young virgins to bathe in their blood: either an unrepentant predator or an ambitious proto-feminist and the victim of a political conspiracy.

Either way, Marcia’s love caused Veronika pain. “After the first night, I felt as if I had left an old world behind,” Veronika wrote just before her death in 1870. “But despite the excitement, I missed my old world, where I understood every crevice, every stone. Now, I existed somewhere wild and open, a forest much larger than the one outside of the manor-house. A forest I could never imagine understanding with any intimacy. Marcia did this to me. Marcia brought me here.” So what to make, then, of Veronika’s sense of loss? Could it be that, despite the crippling effects of Marcia’s affections, Veronika would have rather died than been without her?

There is one other strange and surprising detail in the letters, which LeFanu excluded for reasons unknown: throughout the duration of their correspondence, a comet hung in the sky above them. Their back-and-forth frequently mentions this apparition and the acute strangeness it provoked. (It is reasonable to assume that the vivid scenes Veronika paints are partially due to its influence.) For her part, Dr. Leight theorized that the comet they wrote of was the historical Solo Comet—now called Solo 9—as its accompanying distortion and escalation of memory syncs with their accounts. It is the same comet that hangs over us all as I write this essay; it similarly visited Dr. Leight in the years following her most important scholarship. The fact that its name mirrors Veronika’s profound loneliness is as unluckily tragic as any other detail in this account.^{ix}

Logistics: The accompanying text includes footnotes of both a practical and illustrative nature. It is useful, for example, to have a sense of the many provinces and cities referenced here and their historical and contemporary dimensions. The text is edited to reflect a more modern grammatical sensibility where necessary. There are also places where your faithful editor has done her best to interrupt LeFanu’s passionate and unrequited love affair with unnecessary commas.

You are likely wondering why I did not restore the original complexity and length of Veronika’s letters to this edition. There are a few reasons: First, there is reason to believe that even the collection of correspondence discovered by Dr. Leight was not complete, and I remain eternally hopeful that Veronika’s uncensored voice will one day have its due. The second is more complex, and infinitely more petty: I wished this edition to bear LeFanu’s shame. I wish the reader to come to the book with a complete understanding of its inadequacy.

The act of interacting with text—that is to say, of reading—is that of inserting one’s self into what is static and unchanging so that it might

pump with fresh blood. Having read this introduction, I hope you will enter into *Carmilla* thusly, using your fingertips and mouth and mind to locate the lacunae where LeFanu excised pieces of Veronika's account, the hallways haunted by the specters of truth and phantoms of passion. See if you cannot perceive what exists below: the erotic relationship of two high-strung and lonely young women. The shared metropolis of their dreaming. An aborted picnic in the ruins.

CARMEN MARIA MACHADO

Taos, New Mexico

June 22, 2018

i University of Pennsylvania Press, 2009.

ii There is no doubt that the events that inspired *Dracula* would have interested Doctor Fontenot tremendously, but he died of pulmonary tuberculosis in 1885, over a decade before its publication and well before its central events took place.

iii Though it has no particular bearing on either this introduction or the text, Veronika Hausle's great-granddaughter achieved her own measure of fame: she was acclaimed vocalist Madelena Deloni, born Systana Carvokka, whose famous Argentinian recital in 1936 inspired the seminal work of neurophysicist Geoffrey Sonnabend, *Obliscence: Theories of Forgetting and the Problem of Matter* .

iv From Amy Parker's "Kingdom by the Sea," on *Lolita* : "The cruelest part is its introduction. Did you realize he killed her off? I didn't. Who reads an introduction? But it is true. Right away, without ceremony, he undoes her. He anticipates any attempts on the part of her readers to help her, to free her, to resist the text by imagining her beyond its borders, by allowing her, perhaps, an adulthood. . . . Before we ever meet her, he nails her down in her coffin. The book is her tomb—she's walled up in it."

v In Bram Stoker's *Dracula* , Professor Van Helsing uses a wild rose to immobilize the entombed vampire. In one of her unpublished letters, Veronika revealed that the wild rose was a symbol of affection between herself and Marcia; they left clipped branches for each other on their respective pillows.

vi Its principle researcher, Baron Dr. Karl Ludwig von Reichenbach, was responsible for several significant scientific advancements, including the invention of the first synthetic dye.

vii It is no coincidence that *Carmilla* is the name of a Japanese lesbian magazine.

viii This description remained in *Carmilla* ; the knots people have tied themselves into to describe it as anything *but* an orgasm are almost comedic.

ix There is also the detail of Dr. Leight's eventual suicide in 1984.

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PROLOGUE

Upon a paper attached to the following narrative, Doctor Hesselius has written a rather elaborate note, which he accompanies with a reference to his essay on the strange subject which the manuscript illuminates. This mysterious subject he treats in his essay with his usual learning and acumen, and with remarkable directness and abridgment. It will form but one volume of the series of that extraordinary man's collected papers.

As I publish the case in these volumes, simply for the interest of the laity, I shall not prologue the narrator. And, after due consideration, I have also determined to abstain from presenting any *précis* of the learned Doctor's reasoning or extract from his statement on a subject which he describes as "involving, not improbably, some of the profoundest arcana of our dual existence."

I was anxious, upon discovering this paper, to re-open the correspondence commenced by Doctor Hesselius so many years before with a person so clever and careful as his informant seems to have been. Much to my regret, however, I found that she had died in the interval.¹ That being said, she probably could have added little to the narrative which she communicates, with such fastidious detail, in the following pages.

— J. Sheridan LeFanu, 1871

1 Enter here knowing that she is already dead.

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CHAPTER I

AN EARLY FRIGHT

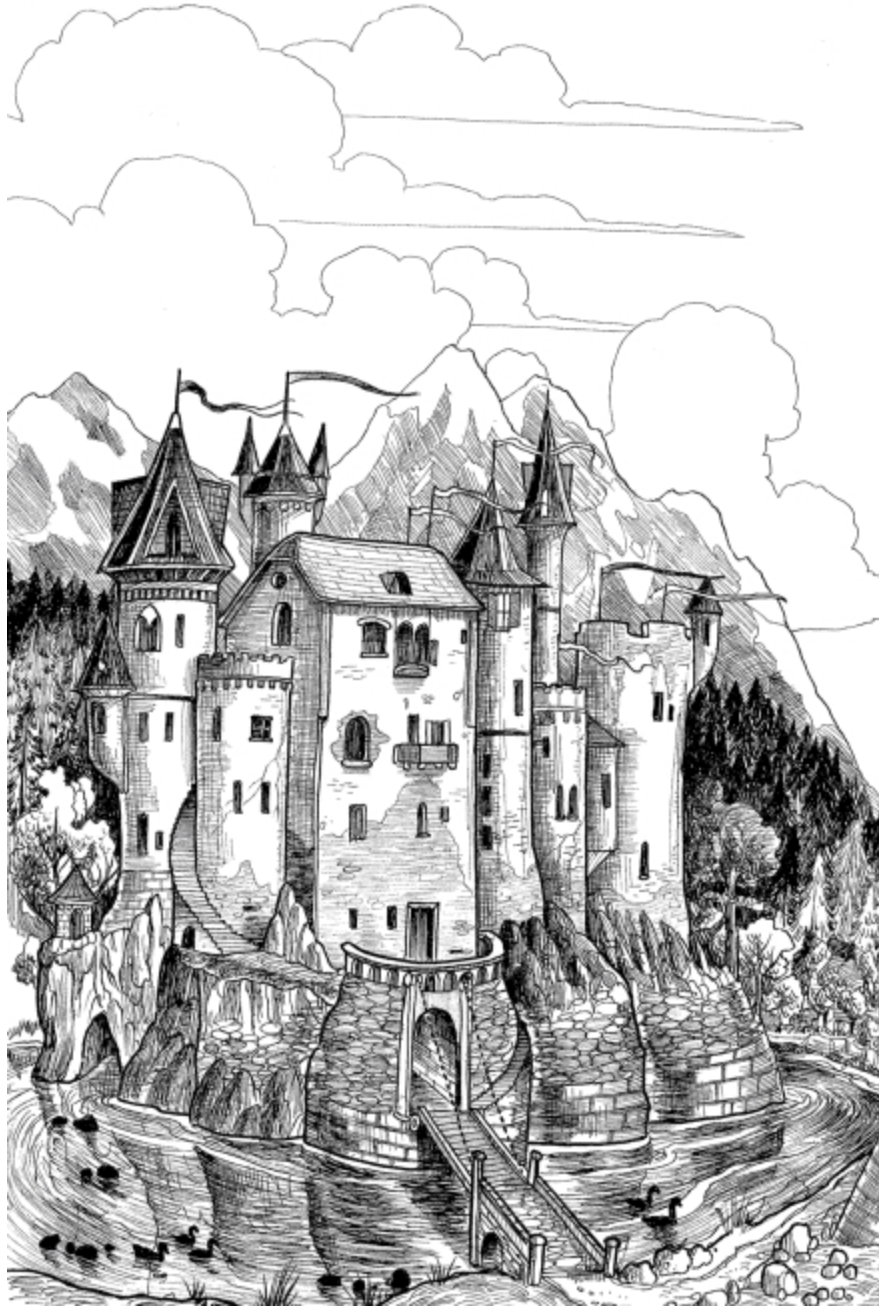
In Styria, ² we—though by no means magnificent people—inhabit a manor-house. A small income in that part of the world goes a great way; eight or nine hundred a year does wonders. Ours would have barely answered among wealthy people at home. (My father is English, and I bear an English name; yet, I have never seen England.) But here, in this lonely and primitive place, where everything is so marvelously cheap, I really don't see how ever so much more money would at all materially add to our comforts or luxuries.

My father was in the Austrian service and retired upon a pension and his patrimony. He purchased this feudal residence, and the small estate on which it stands, at a bargain.

Nothing can be more picturesque or solitary. It stands on a slight eminence in a forest. The road, very old and narrow, passes in front of its drawbridge—never raised in my time—and its moat is stocked with perch and sailed over by many swans; on its surface float white fleets of water-lilies.

Over all this the manor-house shows its many-windowed front; its towers, and its Gothic chapel.

The forest opens in an irregular and very picturesque glade before its gate, and at the right a steep Gothic bridge carries the road over a stream that winds in deep shadow through the wood.



I have said that this is a very lonely place. Judge whether or not I say truth. Looking from the hall door towards the road, the forest in which our castle stands extends in every direction. The nearest inhabited village is about seven of your English miles to the east. The nearest inhabited manor-house of any historic association—that of old General Spielsdor—is nearly twenty miles away to the west.

I have said “the nearest *inhabited* village,” because there is, only three miles westward—that is to say, in the direction of General Spielsdorf’s manor-house—a ruined village. There sits a quaint, roofless little church, in the aisle of which are the moldering tombs of the proud family of Karnstein. Now extinct, they once owned the desolate château which overlooks the silent ruins of the town from the thick of the forest.

Respecting the cause of the desertion of this striking and melancholy spot, there is a legend which I shall relate to you another time.

Listen, and wonder! I must tell you, now, how very small is the party who constitute the inhabitants of our castle. (I don’t include servants, or those dependents who occupy rooms in the buildings attached to the manor-house.)

My father, who is the kindest man on earth, but growing old; and I, at the date of my story, only nineteen. Eight years have passed since then.

I and my father constituted the family at the manor-house! My mother, a Styrian lady, died in my infancy, but I had a good-natured governess, who had been with me since then. I could not remember a time when her fat, benevolent face was not a familiar picture in my memory. She was Madame Perrodon, a native of Berne,³ whose care and good nature now in part supplied to me what was lost with the death of my mother. She made a third at our little dinner party.

There was a fourth, Mademoiselle De Lafontaine, a lady you might call a “finishing governess.” She spoke French and German, and Madame Perrodon French and broken English, to which my father and I added unbroken English. We did this partly for patriotism’s sake and partly to prevent its becoming a lost language between us. The consequence was a Babel, at which strangers used to laugh, and which I shall make no attempt to reproduce in this narrative.

There were also two or three young lady friends, close to my own age, who were occasional visitors.

These were our regular social resources; but of course there were chance visits from “neighbors” of only five or six leagues’ distance. My life was, notwithstanding, rather a solitary one, I can assure you.

My governesses had as much control as you might imagine they had over a rather spoiled girl whose father allowed her to have her own way in nearly everything.

The first occurrence in my life which produced a terrible impression upon my mind—one which, in fact, never has been equaled—was one of the very earliest incidents I can recollect. Some people will think it so trifling that it should not be recorded here. You will see, however, by and by, why I mention it.

The nursery, which I had all to myself, was a large room in the uppermost story of the manor-house, with a steep oak roof. I can’t have been more than six years old the night I awoke and, from my bed, failed to see the nursery-maid. Neither was my nurse there; and I thought myself alone.

I was not frightened, for I was one of those happy children who are studiously kept in ignorance of ghost stories, of fairy tales, of the lore that makes us cover up our heads when the door cracks suddenly or the flicker of a guttering candle makes the shadow of a bed-post dance upon the wall. I was vexed and insulted at finding myself—I imagined—neglected, and I began to whimper in preparation for a burst of sobs.

It was only then that I saw the solemn but very pretty face looking at me from the side of the bed.

The young lady was kneeling with her hands under the coverlet. I looked at her with a kind of pleased wonder and ceased whimpering. She caressed me with her hands and lay down beside me on the bed. She drew me towards her, smiling; I felt immediately soothed, and fell asleep again.

This was the sensation that woke me: as if two needles ran into my breast very deep at the same moment.

I cried loudly. The lady started back, her eyes fixed on me, then slipped down upon the floor and, I thought, hid herself under the bed.

Frightened, I yelled with all my might. Nurse, nursery maid, housekeeper, all came running in, and hearing my story made light of it, soothing me all they could meanwhile. But, child as I was, I could perceive that their faces were pale with uncharacteristic expressions of anxiety, and I saw them look under the bed⁴ and about the room, peep under tables, and pluck open cupboards. The housekeeper whispered to the nurse: "Lay your hand along that hollow in the bed; someone *did* lie there; the place is still warm."

I remember the nursery-maid petting me, and all three examining the place where I told them I felt the puncture and pronouncing that there was no sign visible that any such thing had happened to me.

The housekeeper and the two other servants remained sitting up all night; and from that time a servant always sat with me in the nursery, until I was about fourteen.

I was very nervous for a long time after this. A pale, elderly doctor was called in. How well I remember his long, saturnine face, lightly pitted with smallpox scars, and his voluminous chestnut wig. For a good while, every other day, he came and gave me medicine, which of course I hated.

The morning after I saw this apparition I was in a state of terror, and could not bear to be left alone, daylight though it was. I remember my father coming up and standing at the bedside, talking cheerfully and asking the nurse a number of questions. He laughed very heartily at one of the answers and patted me on the shoulder, kissing me and telling me not to be frightened. It was nothing but a dream, he said, and could not hurt me.

But I was not comforted, for I knew the visit of the strange woman was *not* a dream and knew, instinctively, that she could in fact hurt me.

I was not consoled by the nursery-maid's assuring me that it was she who had come and looked at me and lain down beside me in the bed, and that I must have been half-dreaming not to have known her face.

I remember too, in the course of that day, a venerable old man in a black cassock, coming into the room with the nurse and housekeeper and talking a little to them, and then very kindly to me. His face was sweet and gentle, and he told me they were going to pray. He joined my hands together and told me he desired me to say, softly, while they were praying, "Lord hear all good prayers for us, for Jesus's sake." I think these were the very words, because I often repeated them to myself, and for years afterward my nurse would make me say them in my prayers.

I remember so well the thoughtful, sweet face of that white-haired old man in a black cassock; I remember so well how he stood in that rude, lofty room, with the clumsy furniture of a fashion three hundred years old about him and the scanty light entering through the small lattice. He knelt, and the three women with him, and he prayed aloud with an earnest, quavering voice for what felt like an entire age.

I forget all my life preceding that event. For some time after it is all obscure, also, but the scenes I have just described stand out vividly as the isolated pictures of the phantasmagoria, surrounded by darkness.

² A state in the southeast of Austria.

³ A major city in central Switzerland.

⁴ Imagine, reader, the beautiful woman snarled up in the bed-slats, smelling the nurse's breath as she lifted the bed-skirt.

CHAPTER II

A GUEST

I am now going to tell you something so strange it will require all your faith in my veracity to believe my story. It is not only true, but truth of which I have been an eye-witness.

It was a sweet summer evening, and my father asked me, as he sometimes did, to take a walk with him along our manor-house's beautiful forest vista.

"General Spielsdorf cannot come to us as soon as I had hoped," said my father as we ambled through the landscape.

He was, presently, meant to pay us a weeks-long visit, and we had expected his arrival the next day. He was to have brought with him a young lady, his niece and ward Mademoiselle Rheinfeldt, whom I had never seen, but whom I had heard described as a very charming girl and in whose society I had promised myself many happy days. I was unspeakably disappointed. This visit, and the new acquaintance it promised, had furnished my daydreams for many weeks.

"And how soon does he come?" I asked.

"Not until autumn, I dare say," he answered. "And I am very glad now, dear, that you never knew Mademoiselle Rheinfeldt."

"Why?" I asked.

"Because the poor young lady is dead," he replied. "You were not in the room when I received the general's letter this evening."

I was very much shocked. General Spielsdorf had mentioned in his first letter, six or seven weeks before, that she was not so well as he would like, but there was nothing to suggest the remotest suspicion of danger or death.

“Here is the general’s letter,” he said, handing it to me. “I am afraid he is in great affliction; the letter appears to me to have been written in distraction.”

We sat down on a rough-hewn bench under a group of magnificent lime-trees. The sun was setting with all its melancholy splendor behind the sylvan horizon, and the stream that flows beside our home and passes under the steep old bridge wound through many a group of noble trees and past our feet, reflecting in its current the fading crimson of the sky.⁵ General Spielsdorf’s letter was so extraordinary, so vehement, and in some places so self-contradictory, that I read it twice over—the second time aloud to my father—and was still unable to account for it, except by supposing that grief had unsettled his mind. It read:

I have lost my darling daughter, for as such I loved her. During the last days of dear Bertha’s illness, I was not able to write to you. Before then I had no idea of the danger. I have lost her, and now learn all too late. She died in the peace of virtuousness and the glorious hope of a blessed futurity. The fiend who betrayed our infatuated hospitality has done it all. I thought I was receiving into my house innocence, gaiety, a charming companion for my lost Bertha. Heavens, what a fool I have been! I thank God my child died without a suspicion of the cause of her suffering. She is gone without so much as conjecturing the nature of her illness and the accursed passion of the agent of all this misery. I devote my remaining days to tracking and extinguishing a monster. I am told I may hope to

accomplish my righteous and merciful purpose. At present there is scarcely a gleam of light to guide me. I curse my conceited incredulity, my despicable affectation of superiority, my blindness, my obstinacy—all—too late. I cannot write or talk collectedly now. I am distracted. As soon as I have a little recovered, I mean to devote myself for a time to enquiry, which may possibly lead me as far as Vienna. Sometime in the autumn, two months hence, or earlier if I live, I will see you—that is, if you permit me; I will then tell you all that I scarce dare put upon paper now. Farewell. Pray for me, dear friend.

In these terms ended this strange letter. Though I had never seen Bertha Rheinfeldt, my eyes filled with tears at the news of her loss.

The sun had now set. I returned the general's letter to my father.

It was a soft clear evening, and we loitered in the gloaming, speculating upon the possible meanings of the violent and incoherent sentences I had just read. We had nearly a mile to walk before reaching the manor-house, and by that time the moon was shining brilliantly. At the drawbridge we met Madame Perrodon and Mademoiselle De Lafontaine, who had come out without their bonnets to enjoy the exquisite moonlight.

We heard their gabbling, animated dialogue as we approached. We joined them at the drawbridge and turned about to admire with them the beautiful scene.

The glade through which we had just walked lay before us. At our left the narrow road wound away under clumps of lordly trees and was lost to sight amid the thickening forest. At the right the same road crossed the steep and picturesque bridge, near which stood a ruined tower that once guarded the pass; and beyond the bridge rose an abrupt hill, covered with trees and shadows and ivy-clustered rocks. Over the grass and grounds a thin film of mist was curling like smoke, marking

the distances with a transparent veil. Here and there we could see the river faintly flashing in the moonlight. No softer, sweeter scene could be imagined. The news I had just heard made it melancholy; but still nothing could disturb its character of profound serenity. My father and I stood looking in silence over the expanse.

The two good governesses, standing a little way behind us, discoursed upon the scene, waxing eloquent about the moon. Madame Perrodon was fat, middle-aged, and romantic, and talked and sighed poetically. Mademoiselle De Lafontaine—in the tradition of her father, who was a German assumed to be psychological, metaphysical, and something of a mystic—declared that when the moon shone with such intensity it was well-known that it indicated a particular type of spiritual activity. The effect of the full moon in such a state of brilliancy was manifold, she said. It acted on dreams, it acted on lunacy, it acted on nervous people; it had marvelous physical influences connected with life. Mademoiselle related that her cousin, who was a mate on a merchant ship, once took a nap on deck on such a night, lying on his back with his face full in the light of the moon. He woke after a dream of an old woman clawing him by the cheek with his features horribly drawn to one side; his countenance had never quite recovered its equilibrium.

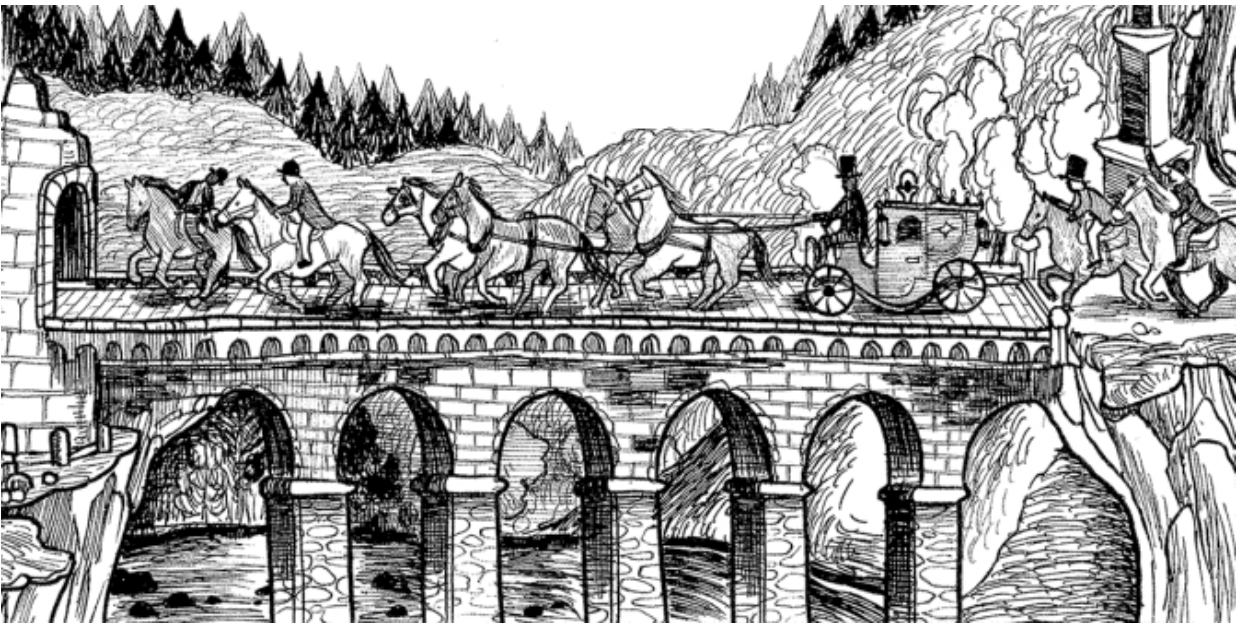
“The moon, this night,” she said, “is full of odylic and magnetic influence. And see, when you look behind you at the front of the manor-house, how all its windows flash and twinkle with that silvery splendor, as if unseen hands have lighted up the rooms to receive fairy guests.”

It was, I thought, a moment in which my sorrowful spirit, indisposed to talk itself, found the talk of others pleasant to its listless ears. I gazed on, pleased with the tinkle of the ladies’ conversation.

“I’m in one of my moping moods tonight,” said my father after a silence, and then, quoting Shakespeare: “In truth I know not why I am so sad: It wearies me; you say it wearies you; But how I got it—came by it.”⁶

“I forget the rest. But I feel as if some great misfortune is hanging over us. I suppose the poor general’s afflicted letter has had something to do with it.”

The sound of carriage wheels and many hoofs upon the road arrested our attention. It seemed to be approaching from the high ground overlooking the bridge, and very soon it emerged: two horsemen, then a carriage drawn by four horses. Two men rode behind. It was the traveling coach of a person of rank; and we were all immediately absorbed in watching that very unusual spectacle.



As the carriage passed the summit of the steep bridge, one of the lead horses took fright, and the whole team broke into a wild gallop together, dashing between the horsemen who rode in front and thundering along the road towards us with the speed of a hurricane. From the carriage window came a long and terrible scream.

We advanced in curiosity and horror: my father in silence, the rest of us exclaiming our fear.

The suspense did not last long. Just before the castle drawbridge, there stood by the roadside a magnificent lime-tree and an ancient stone

cross, at sight of which the horses, now going at a pace that was perfectly frightful, swerved. The wheel buckled over the projecting roots of the tree.

I knew what was coming. I covered my eyes and turned my head away; my governesses cried out.

I opened them again to a scene of utter confusion. Two of the horses lay sprawled on the ground. The carriage lay upon its side with two wheels spinning in the air; the men were busy removing the traces, and a lady with a commanding air and figure climbed out. She stood with clasped hands, raising a handkerchief to her eyes. Through the carriage door was now lifted a young lady, who appeared to be lifeless.

My dear old father was already beside the elder lady with his hat in his hand, tendering his aid and the resources of his manor-house. The lady did not appear to hear him or to have eyes for anything but the slender girl being placed against the slope of the bank.

I approached; the young lady was apparently stunned, but she was certainly not dead. My father, who fancied himself something of a physician, placed his fingers on her wrist. He assured the lady—who declared herself the girl's mother—that her pulse, though faint and irregular, was still perceptible.

There was something in this lady's air and appearance so distinguished and imposing, and in her manner so engaging, one could not help the conviction that she was a person of consequence. She was a fine-looking woman for her time of life and must have once been handsome; she was tall and pale, but not thin; dressed in black velvet and with a proud and commanding countenance, though now agitated strangely. She clasped her hands and looked upward, as if in a momentary transport of celestial gratitude, but immediately returned with a theatrical monologue.

“Was ever a being so born to calamity?” she cried. “Here I am, on a journey of life and death, in which to lose an hour is to lose all. My child will not have recovered sufficiently to resume her route for who can say how long. I must leave her: I cannot, dare not, delay. How far

on, sir, can you tell, is the nearest village? I must leave her there—and shall not see my darling, or even hear of her, till my return three months hence.”

I plucked my father by the coat and whispered earnestly in his ear: “Oh, Papa! Pray ask her to let her stay with us—it would be so delightful. Do, pray.”

“If Madame will entrust her child to the care of my daughter, and of her good governess, Madame Perrodon, and permit her to remain as our guest under my charge until her return, it will confer a distinction and an obligation upon us, and we shall treat her with all the care and devotion which so sacred a trust deserves.”

“I cannot do that, sir; it would be to task your kindness and chivalry too cruelly,” said the lady, distractedly.

“It would, on the contrary, confer onto us a very great kindness at the moment when we most need it. My daughter has just been disappointed by a cruel misfortune, in a visit from which she had long anticipated a great deal of happiness. If you confide this young lady to our care, it will be her best consolation. The nearest village on your route is distant and affords no such inn at which you could think of placing your daughter, and you cannot allow her to continue her journey for any considerable distance without danger. If, as you say, you are unable to suspend your journey, you must part with her tonight. Nowhere could you do so with more honest assurances of care and tenderness than here.”

By this time the carriage was back in its upright position, and the horses, quite tractable, in their traces again. The lady threw on her daughter a glance which was not quite so affectionate as one might have anticipated. She beckoned slightly to my father and withdrew two or three steps with him out of hearing. There, she talked to him with a fixed and stern countenance, not at all like that with which she had hitherto spoken. I was filled with wonder that my father did not seem to perceive the change and also unspeakably curious to learn what it could

be that she was speaking in his ear with so much earnestness and rapidity.

For two or three minutes she remained thus employed, then turned and walked to where her daughter lay, supported by Madame Perrodon. She knelt beside her for a moment and whispered, it seemed, a little benediction in her ear; then, hastily kissing her, she stepped into her carriage.

The door was closed, the footmen in stately liveries jumped up behind, the outriders spurred on, the postilions cracked their whips, the horses broke into a furious canter that threatened to become a gallop, and the carriage whirled away, followed at the same rapid pace by the two horsemen in the rear.

5 Imagine it, reader: a river of blood.

6 A paraphrase of the opening lines of *Merchant of Venice* .

CHAPTER III

WE COMPARE NOTES

We followed the cortège with our eyes until it was swiftly lost to sight in the misty wood. The sound of the hoofs and the wheels died away in the silent night air.

Nothing remained to assure us that the adventure had not been an illusion of a moment but the young lady, who just at that moment opened her eyes. I could not see, for her face was turned from me, but she raised her head and looked about, and a very sweet voice whinnied, “Where is Mama?”

Our good Madame Perrodon answered tenderly and added some comfortable assurances.

I then heard her ask: “Where am I? What is this place?” Then, “I don’t see the carriage; and Matska, where is she?”

Madame answered all her questions insofar as she understood them, and gradually the young lady remembered how the misadventure came about. She was glad to hear that no one was hurt, but on learning that her mama had left her here until her return in three months, she wept.

I was going to add my consolations to those of Madame Perrodon when Mademoiselle De Lafontaine placed her hand upon my arm. “Don’t approach,” she said. “One at a time is as much as she can at present converse with; a very little excitement would possibly overpower her now.”

As soon as she is comfortably in bed, I thought, I will run up to her room and see her.

My father in the meantime had sent a servant on horseback for the physician, who lived about two leagues away; and a bedroom was being prepared for the young lady's reception. The stranger rose and, leaning on Madame's arm, walked slowly over the drawbridge and through the front gate.

In the hall, servants waited to receive her, and she was conducted forthwith to her room.

Our drawing room was long, with four windows that overlooked the moat and drawbridge and the forest beyond. It was furnished in old carved oak, with large cabinets and chairs cushioned with crimson Utrecht velvet. The walls were draped in tapestries surrounded with great gold frames, the figures large as life and in ancient and curious costume, hunting, hawking, and making merriment. It was not so stately as to be uncomfortable; here, we had our tea. (For with his usual patriotic leanings, my father insisted that the national beverage should make its appearance regularly with our coffee and chocolate.) We sat there that night and over lit candles discussed the adventure of the evening.

Madame Perrodon and Mademoiselle De Lafontaine joined us. The young stranger had hardly lain down in her bed when she descended into a deep sleep, and those ladies had left her in the care of a servant.

"How do you like our guest?" I asked as soon as Madame entered. "Tell me all about her?"

"I like her extremely," answered Madame. "She is, I almost think, the prettiest creature I ever saw; about your age, and so gentle and nice."

"She is absolutely beautiful," added Mademoiselle, who had peeked into the stranger's room.

"And such a sweet voice!" said Madame Perrodon.

“Did you notice the other woman in the carriage? The one who did not get out,” inquired Mademoiselle, “but only looked from the window?”

“No, we did not see her.”

Mademoiselle described a hideous black woman with a colored turban on her head who was gazing all the time from the carriage window, grinning sinisterly towards the ladies, with gleaming white eyeballs and teeth set as if in fury.⁷

“Did you notice what an ill-looking pack of men the servants were?” asked Madame.

“Yes,” said my father, who had just come in, “ugly, hangdog-looking fellows, as ever I beheld in my life. I hope they don’t rob the poor lady in the forest. They are clever rogues, however; they got everything to rights in a minute.”

“I dare say they are worn out with too long traveling,” said Madame. “Besides looking wicked, their faces were so strangely lean and dark and sullen. I am very curious; but I dare say the young lady will tell us all about it tomorrow, if she is sufficiently recovered.”

“I don’t think she will,” said my father with a mysterious smile and a little nod of his head, as if he knew more about it than he cared to tell us. This made us all the more inquisitive as to what had passed between him and the lady in the black velvet before her departure.

We were scarcely alone when I entreated him to tell me. He did not need much pressing.

“There is no particular reason why I should not tell you. She expressed a reluctance to trouble us with the care of her daughter, saying she was in delicate health, and nervous. But not subject to any kind of seizure—she volunteered that—nor to any illusion; being, in fact, perfectly sane.”

“How very odd to say all that!” I interrupted. “It was so unnecessary.”

“In any event, it *was* said,” he laughed, “and as you wish to know all that passed, which was indeed very little, I will tell you. She then said, ‘I am making a long journey of *vital* importance’—she emphasized the word—‘rapid and secret; I shall return for my child in three months; in the meantime, she will be silent as to who we are, whence we come, and whither we are traveling.’ That is all she said. She spoke very pure French. When she said the word *secret*, she paused for a few seconds, her eyes sternly fixed on mine. And then you saw how quickly she was gone. I hope I have not done a very foolish thing in taking charge of the young lady.”

For my part, I was delighted. I longed to see and talk to her and was only waiting till the doctor should give me leave. You who live in towns can have no idea how great an event the introduction of a new friend is, in such a solitude as this.

The doctor did not arrive till nearly one o’clock; but I could no more have gone to my bed and slept than I could have overtaken, on foot, the carriage in which the princess in black velvet had driven away.

When the physician came down to the drawing-room, it was to report very favorably upon his patient. She was now sitting up, her pulse quite regular, apparently perfectly well. She had sustained no injury, and the little shock to her nerves had dissipated. There could be no harm certainly in my seeing her, if we both wished it.

With this permission, I sent a servant to ask whether she would allow me to visit her for a few minutes in her room.

The servant returned immediately to say that she desired nothing more. You may be sure I was not long in availing myself of this permission.

Our visitor lay in one of the handsomest rooms in the manor-house. It was, perhaps, a little stately. There was a somber piece of tapestry opposite the foot of the bed, representing Cleopatra with the asps to her bosom.⁸ Other solemn classic scenes were displayed, a little faded, upon the other walls. But there was gold carving, and rich and varied

color enough in the other decorations of the room, to more than redeem the gloom of the old tapestry.

There were candles at the bedside. She was sitting up, her slender, pretty figure wreathed in a silk dressing gown embroidered with flowers; she was draped in a thick quilt, which her mother had thrown over her feet as she lay upon the ground.

What was it that, as I reached her bedside and began my greeting, struck me dumb in a moment and made me recoil from her? I will tell you: I saw the very face which had visited me in my childhood at night, which remained so fixed in my memory, and on which I had for so many years so often ruminated with horror. It was pretty, even beautiful, and wore the same melancholy expression as when I first beheld it. Her countenance kindled into a strange, fixed smile of recognition. There was a silence of fully a minute, and then at length *she* spoke; I could not.

“How wonderful!” she exclaimed. “Twelve years ago, I saw your face in a dream, and it has haunted me ever since.”

“Wonderful indeed!” I repeated, pushing through the horror that had struck me dumb. “Twelve years ago, in vision or reality, *I* certainly saw you. I could not forget your face. It has remained before my eyes ever since.”

Her smile softened. Whatever I had fancied strange in it was gone, and it and her dimpling cheeks were now delightfully pretty and intelligent. I felt reassured, and bid her welcome. I told her how much pleasure her accidental arrival had given us all, and especially what a happiness it was to me.

I took her hand as I spoke. I was a little shy, as lonely people are, but the situation made me eloquent and even bold. She pressed my hand, she laid hers upon it, and her eyes glowed as she peered into mine. She smiled again, blushed, and answered my welcome very prettily.

I sat down beside her, still wondering; and she said:

“I must tell you my vision about you; it is so very strange that you and I should have had of the other so vivid a dream; that each of us should have seen, I you and you me, looking as we do now, when of course we both were mere children. I was a child, about six years old, and I awoke from a confused and troubled dream, and found myself in a room unlike my nursery, wainscoted clumsily in some dark wood. There were cupboards and bedsteads and chairs and benches placed about it. The beds were, I thought, all empty, and the room without anyone but myself in it. After looking around for some time, and admiring especially an iron candlestick with two branches, I crept under one of the beds to reach the window; but as I rose I heard someone crying. Looking up, while I was still upon my knees, I saw *you*—most assuredly you—as I see you now: a beautiful young lady, with golden hair and large blue eyes, and lips—your lips—you, as you are here. Your looks won me; I climbed on the bed and put my arms about you, and I think we both fell asleep. I was aroused by a cry; you were sitting up screaming. I was frightened and slipped down upon the ground and, it seemed to me, lost consciousness for a moment; when I came to myself, I was again in my nursery at home. Your face I have never forgotten since. I could not be misled by mere resemblance. You are the lady I saw.”

It was now my turn to relate my corresponding vision, which I did, to the undisguised wonder of my new acquaintance.

“I don’t know which of us should be more afraid of the other,” she said, again smiling. “If you were less pretty I think I should be very much afraid of you, but being as you are, and you and I both so young, I feel only that I have made your acquaintance twelve years ago and have already a right to your intimacy; at all events it does seem as if we were destined, from our earliest childhood, to be friends. I wonder whether you feel as strangely drawn towards me as I do to you; I have never had a friend—shall I find one now?” She sighed, and her fine dark eyes lit upon me.

The truth is, I felt rather unaccountably towards the beautiful stranger. I did feel, as she said, “drawn towards her,” but there was also something of repulsion. In this ambiguous feeling, however, the sense of attraction immensely prevailed. She interested and won me; she was so beautiful and so indescribably engaging.

I perceived now something of languor and exhaustion stealing over her and hastened to bid her good night.

“The doctor thinks,” I added, “that you ought to have a maid to sit up with you tonight; one of ours is waiting, and you will find her a very useful and quiet creature.”

“How kind of you, but I could not sleep with an attendant in the room. I shan’t require any assistance—and now, I shall confess my weakness: I am haunted with a terror of robbers. Our house was robbed once, and two servants murdered, so I always lock my door. It has become a habit—and you look so kind I know you will forgive me. I see there is a key in the lock.” She held me close in her pretty arms for a moment and whispered in my ear, “Good night, darling, it is very hard to part with you, but good night; tomorrow, but not early, I shall see you again.”

She sank back on the pillow with a sigh, and her fine eyes followed me with a fond and melancholy gaze, and she murmured again, “Good night, dear friend.”

Young people like, and even love, on impulse. I was flattered by the evident, though as yet undeserved, fondness she showed me. I liked the confidence with which she at once received me. She was determined that we should be very near friends.

The next day came and we met again. I was delighted with my companion in many respects. Her looks lost nothing in daylight—she was certainly the most beautiful creature I had ever seen, and the unpleasant remembrance of the face presented in my early dream had lost the effect of the first unexpected recognition. She confessed that she had experienced a similar shock on seeing me, and precisely the

same faint antipathy that had mingled with my admiration of her. We now laughed together over our momentary horrors.

⁷ Literary scholars have many thoughts about this character, whom most believe to be the “Matska” Carmilla inquires about when she regains consciousness. The character’s racist and sexist othering is evident; she also may be the old woman Mademoiselle De Lafontaine talks about in the tale of her cousin the sailor, the one he dreamt about. Most interestingly, Valerie Guyant suggests in a 2014 paper that *matska* —a word which refers to a large cat in Slovenian, Slovakian, Serbian, Romanian, and Hungarian, all languages that would have been spoken in Styria during this era—is in fact the large black cat that appears to both Laura and Bertha. “This would explain the striking difference between this encounter, when Laura is terrified, and her later dreams of sensual kisses that leave her weakened but not afraid,” she writes. “If this is the case, then Carmilla may be innocent of the crimes for which she is executed, offering a unique possibility for critical analysis.”

⁸ Reader, do you remember? Rather than endure the shame of being paraded around by Octavian, she took up an asp and permitted it to bite her. She invited death.

CHAPTER IV

HER HABITS—A SAUNTER

I told you that I was charmed with her in most particulars.

There were some that did not please me so well.

I shall begin by describing her. She was above the middle height of women; slender, and wonderfully graceful. Except that her movements were languid—*very* languid—indeed, there was nothing in her appearance to indicate an invalid. Her complexion was rich and brilliant; her features were small and beautifully formed; her eyes large, dark, and lustrous. Her hair was quite wonderful—I never saw hair so magnificently thick and long when it was down about her shoulders; I often placed my hands under it and laughed with wonder at its weight. It was exquisitely fine and soft, and in color a rich, very dark brown, with something of a gold sheen. I loved to let it down, tumbling with its own weight, as, in her room, she lay back in her chair talking in her sweet low voice. I used to fold and braid it, and spread it out and play with it. Heavens! If I had but known all!

I said there were particulars which did not please me. I have told you that her confidence won me the first night I saw her; but I found that she exercised with respect to herself, her mother, her history, everything in fact connected with her life, plans, and people, an ever-wakeful reserve. I dare say I was unreasonable, and perhaps I was wrong; I dare say I ought to have respected the solemn injunction laid upon my father by the stately lady in black velvet. But curiosity is a restless and unscrupulous passion, and no one girl can endure, with patience, hers

being baffled by another. What harm could it do anyone to tell me what I so ardently desired to know? Had she no trust in my good sense or honor? Why would she not believe me when I assured her, so solemnly, that I would not divulge one syllable of what she told me to any mortal breathing? There was a coldness, it seemed to me, beyond her years, in her smiling, melancholy, persistent refusal to afford me the least ray of light.

I cannot say we quarreled upon this point, for she would not quarrel upon any. It was, of course, very unfair of me to press her, very ill-bred, but I really could not help it.

I might just as well have let it alone. What she did tell me amounted, in my unconscionable estimation, to nothing. It was all summed up in three very vague disclosures:

First.—Her name was Carmilla.

Second.—Her family was very ancient and noble.

Third.—Her home lay in the direction of the west.

She would not tell me the name of her family, nor their armorial bearings, nor the name of their estate, not even the country they lived in.

Do not suppose that I worried her incessantly on these subjects. I watched for opportunity and insinuated rather than urged my inquiries. Once or twice, I did attack her more directly. But no matter what my tactics, the result was, invariably, utter failure. Reproaches and caresses were all lost upon her. (But I must add this: Her evasion was conducted with so pretty a melancholy and deprecation, with so many passionate declarations of her liking for me and trust in my honor, and with so many promises that I would, one day, know all, I could not find it in my heart long to be angry with her.)

She placed her pretty arms about my neck, drew me to her, and lay her cheek to mine, murmuring with her lips near my ear, “Dearest, your little heart is wounded. Do not think me cruel because I obey the irresistible law of my strength and weakness; if your dear heart is

wounded, my wild heart bleeds with yours. In the rapture of my enormous humiliation I live in your warm life, and you shall die—die, sweetly die—into mine. I cannot help it; as I draw near to you, you, in your turn, will draw near to others, and learn the rapture of that cruelty, which yet is love; so, for a while, seek to know no more of me and mine, but trust me with all your loving spirit.” And when she had spoken such a rhapsody, she would press me more closely in her trembling embrace and lay soft kisses upon my cheek.

Her agitations and her language were unintelligible to me. From these foolish embraces, which were not of very frequent occurrence, I used to wish to extricate myself; but my energies seemed to fail me. Her murmured words sounded like a lullaby in my ear and soothed my resistance into a trance, from which I only seemed to recover myself when she withdrew her arms.

In these mysterious moods I did not like her. I experienced a strange, tumultuous excitement that was pleasurable, ever and anon, mingled with a vague sense of fear and disgust. I had no distinct thoughts about her while such scenes lasted, but I was conscious of a love growing into adoration, and also of abhorrence. This, I know, is a paradox, but I can make no other attempt to explain the feeling.



I now write, after an interval of more than ten years, with a trembling hand, and with a confused and horrible recollection of certain occurrences and situations in the ordeal through which I was unconsciously passing, though with a vivid and very sharp remembrance of the main current of my story. But, I suspect, in all lives there are certain emotional scenes—those in which our passions have been most wildly and terribly roused—that are above all others the most vaguely and dimly remembered.

Sometimes after an hour of apathy, my strange and beautiful companion would take my hand and hold it with a fond pressure, renewed again and again—blushing softly, gazing in my face with

languid and burning eyes, and breathing so fast that her dress rose and fell with the tumultuous respiration. It was like the ardor of a lover; it embarrassed me; it was hateful and yet overpowering; and with gloating eyes she drew me to her. Her hot lips traveled along my cheek in kisses; and she would whisper, almost in sobs, "You are mine, you *shall* be mine, you and I are one forever." Then she would throw herself back in her chair with her small hands over her eyes, leaving me trembling.

"Are we related?" I used to ask. "What can you mean by all this? I remind you perhaps of someone whom you love; but you must not, I hate it; I don't know you—I don't know myself when you look so and talk so."

She sighed at my vehemence, then turned away and dropped my hand.

Respecting these very extraordinary manifestations I strove in vain to form any satisfactory theory. It was unmistakably a momentary breaking out of suppressed instinct and emotion. Was she, notwithstanding her mother's volunteered denial, subject to brief visitations of insanity; or was there here a disguise and a romance? I had read in old storybooks of such things. What if a boyish lover had found his way into the house and sought to pursue his paramour in masquerade with the assistance of a clever old adventuress? (But there were many things against this hypothesis, highly interesting as it was to my vanity. I could boast of no masculine attentions.)

Between these passionate moments there were long intervals of gaiety and brooding melancholy, during which—except that I detected her eyes so full of fire and following me—I might have been as nothing to her. In these brief periods of mysterious excitement her ways were girlish; and there was always a languor about her, quite incompatible with a masculine system in a state of health.

In some respects, her habits were odd. Perhaps not so singular in the opinion of a town lady like you, but as they appeared to us rustic people. She used to come down very late, generally not till one o'clock; she would then take a cup of chocolate but eat nothing; we then went

out for a walk, which was a mere saunter. She seemed, almost immediately, exhausted, and either returned to the manor-house or sat on one of the benches that were placed, here and there, among the trees. This was a bodily languor with which her mind did not sympathize. She was always an animated talker, and very intelligent.

She sometimes alluded for a moment to her own home or mentioned an adventure or situation, or an early recollection, which indicated a people of strange manners, and described customs of which I knew nothing. I gathered from these chance hints that her native country was much more remote than I had at first fancied.

As we sat one afternoon under the trees, a funeral passed us by. It was that of a pretty young girl whom I had often seen, the daughter of one of the rangers of the forest. The poor man was walking behind the coffin of his darling; she was his only child, and he looked quite heartbroken. Peasants walking two by two came behind, singing a funeral hymn. I rose to mark my respect as they passed and joined in the hymn they were very sweetly singing.



My companion shook me a little roughly, and I turned surprised.

“Don’t you perceive how discordant that is?” she said, brusquely.

“On the contrary, I think it very sweet,” I answered, vexed at the interruption and very uncomfortable, lest the people who composed the little procession should observe and resent what she was saying.

I resumed, therefore, instantly, and was again interrupted. “You pierce my ears,” said Carmilla, almost angrily, stopping them with her tiny fingers.⁹ “Besides, how can you tell that your religion and mine are the same? Your forms wound me, and I hate funerals. What a fuss! Why, *you* must die—*everyone* must die—and all are happier when they do. Come home.”

“My father has gone on with the clergyman to the churchyard. I thought you knew she was to be buried today.”

“*She* ? I don’t trouble my head about peasants. I don’t know who she is,” answered Carmilla, with a flash from her fine eyes.

“She is the poor girl who fancied she saw a ghost a fortnight ago and has been dying ever since. Until yesterday, when she expired.”

“Tell me nothing about ghosts. I shan’t sleep tonight if you do.”

“I hope there is no plague or fever coming; all this looks very like it,” I continued. “The swineherd’s young wife died only a week ago, and she thought something had seized her by the throat as she lay in her bed and nearly strangled her. Papa says such horrible fancies do accompany some forms of fever. She had been quite well the day before. She declined afterwards, and died within a week.”

“Well, *her* funeral is over, I hope, and *her* hymn sung, and our ears shan’t be tortured with that discord and jargon. It makes me nervous. Sit down here, beside me. Sit close, hold my hand; press it hard—hard—harder.”

We had moved a little back and come to another bench. She sat down. Her face underwent a change that alarmed and even terrified me for a moment. It darkened and became horribly livid; her teeth and hands were clenched, and she frowned and compressed her lips while she stared down upon the ground at her feet. She trembled all over with

a continuous shudder as irrepressible as ague. All her energies seemed strained to suppress a fit, and at length a low convulsive cry of suffering broke from her and gradually the hysteria subsided. "There! That comes of strangling people with hymns!" she said at last. "Hold me, hold me still. It is passing away."



And so gradually it did; and, perhaps to dissipate the somber impression which the spectacle had left upon me, she became unusually animated and chatty; and so we went home.

This was the first time I had seen her exhibit any definable symptoms of that delicacy of health which her mother had spoken of. It was the first time, also, that I had seen her exhibit anything like temper. Both passed away like a summer cloud, and never but once afterwards did I witness on her part a momentary sign of anger.

I will tell you how it happened.

She and I were looking out of one of the long drawing-room windows, when the figure of a wanderer whom I knew very well entered the courtyard. He used to visit the manor-house generally twice a year. He was a hunchback, with sharp, lean features. He had a pointed black beard and was smiling from ear to ear, showing his white teeth. He was dressed in fawn, black, and scarlet, and crossed with more straps and belts than I could count, from which hung all manner of things. Behind, he carried a magic-lantern and two boxes, in one of which, I knew, was a salamander, and in the other a mandrake. These monsters used to make my father laugh. They were compounded of parts of monkeys, parrots, squirrels, fish, and hedgehogs, dried and stitched together with great neatness and startling effect. He had a fiddle, a box of conjuring apparatus, a pair of foils and masks attached to his belt, several other mysterious cases dangling about him, and a black staff with copper ferrules in his hand. His companion was a rough, spare dog that followed at his heels. The creature stopped short at the drawbridge, and after a little while began to howl dismally.

In the meantime, the mountebank, standing in the midst of the courtyard, raised his grotesque hat and made us a very ceremonious bow, paying his compliments verbosely and in execrable French or German not much better. Then, disengaging his fiddle, he began to scrape a lively air, to which he sang with a merry discord, dancing ludicrously. It made me laugh, in spite of the dog's howling.¹⁰

Then, he advanced to the window with many smiles and salutations, hat in his left hand and fiddle under his arm, and with breathless fluency he gabbled a long advertisement of all his accomplishments, the

resources of the various arts which he placed at our service, and the curiosities and entertainments which it was in his power, at our bidding, to display.

“Will your ladyships be pleased to buy an amulet against the oupire,
¹¹ which I hear is hunting like a wolf through these woods?” he said, dropping his hat on the pavement. “He is killing right and left, and here is a charm that never fails; pin it to your pillow and you may laugh in his face.” These charms consisted of oblong slips of vellum with cabalistic ciphers and diagrams upon them.

Carmilla instantly purchased one, and so did I.

We smiled down upon him, amused; at least, I was. As he looked up in our faces, he seemed to detect something that fixed, for a moment, his curiosity. In an instant he unrolled a leather case, full of all manner of odd little steel instruments.

“See here, my lady,” he said, displaying it, and addressing me, “I profess, among other things less useful, the art of dentistry. Plague take the dog!” he interpolated. “Silence, beast! He howls so that your ladyships can scarcely hear a word. Your noble friend, the young lady at your right, has the sharpest tooth—long, thin, pointed, like an awl, like a needle; ha, ha! With my sharp and long sight, as I look up, I have seen it distinctly; now if it happens to hurt the young lady, and I think it must, here am I; here are my file, my punch, my nippers; I will make it round and blunt, if her ladyship pleases; no longer the tooth of a fish, but of a beautiful young lady such as she is. Hey? Is the young lady displeased? Have I been too bold? Have I offended her?”

The young lady, indeed, looked very angry as she drew back from the window.

“How dares that mountebank insult us so?” she said. “Where is your father? I shall demand redress from him. My father would have had the wretch tied up to the pump, flogged with a cart-whip, and burnt to the bones with the cattle brand!”

She retired from the window a step or two and sat down, and had hardly lost sight of the offender when her wrath subsided as suddenly as it had risen. After that, she gradually recovered her usual tone and seemed to forget the little hunchback and his follies.

My father was out of sorts that evening. He told us that there had been another case very similar to the two fatal ones that had recently occurred: The sister of a young peasant on his estate, only a mile away, was very ill. She had been, as she described it, attacked very nearly in the same way as the others, and was now slowly but steadily declining.

“All this,” said my father, “is strictly referable to natural causes. These poor people infect one another with their superstitions, and so repeat in imagination the images of terror that have infested their neighbors.”

“But that very circumstance frightens one horribly,” said Carmilla.

“How so?” inquired my father.

“I am so afraid of fancying I see such things; I think it would be as bad as reality.”

“We are in God’s hands,” said my gentle father. “Nothing can happen without His permission, and all will end well for those who love Him. He is our faithful creator; He has made us all and will take care of us.”

“Creator! *Nature!* ” said the young lady. “And this disease that invades the country is natural. Nature. All things proceed from Nature—don’t they? All things in the heaven, in the earth, and under the earth, act and live as Nature ordains? I think so.”

“The doctor said he would come here today,” said my father, after a silence. “I want to know what he thinks about it, and what he thinks we had better do.”

“Doctors never did me any good,” said Carmilla.

“Then you have been ill?” I asked.

“More ill than ever you were,” she answered.

“Long ago?”

“Yes, a long time. I suffered from this very illness; but I forget all except my pain and weakness, and these were not so bad as are suffered in other diseases.”

“You were very young then?”

“I dare say, let us talk no more of it. You would not wound a friend?” She looked languidly in my eyes, passed her arm round my waist lovingly, and led me out of the room. My father busied himself over some papers near the window.

“Why does your papa like to frighten us?” said the pretty girl with a sigh and a little shudder.

“He doesn’t, dear Carmilla, it is the very furthest thing from his mind.”

“Are you afraid, dearest?”

“I should be very much if I fancied there was any real danger of my being attacked as those poor people were.”

“You are afraid to die?”

“Yes, everyone is.”

“But to die as lovers may—to die together, so that they may live together. Girls are caterpillars while they live in the world, to be finally butterflies when the summer comes; but in the meantime there are grubs and larvae, don’t you see—each with their peculiar propensities, necessities, and structure. So says Monsieur Buffon, in his big book, in the next room.”

Later in the day the doctor came and was closeted with Papa for some time. He was a skillful man, of sixty and upwards; he wore powder and shaved his pale face as smooth as a pumpkin. He and Papa emerged from the room together, and I heard Papa laugh and say as they came out:

“Well, I do wonder at a wise man like you. What do you say to hippogriffs and dragons?”

The doctor was smiling and shaking his head. “Nevertheless, life and death are mysterious states, and we know little of the resources of

either.”

And so they walked on, and I heard no more. I did not then know what the doctor had been broaching, but I think I guess it now.

9 An early example of the vampire loathing religious imagery and ceremony.

10 When he was a young man, the mountebank had a dream that one day he would encounter a vampire. He set about acquiring as much knowledge as possible about these beings, including charms, trinkets, and spells that would keep them at bay. He did, earnestly, believe them to work, but only because of a coincidence: He stayed safe because of a crucifix stitched into his tunic by a seamstress who had taken a liking to him and was concerned for his safety. The fact that he did not recognize the vampire when he saw her would be an acute embarrassment that would haunt him for the rest of his days. (He later married the seamstress and apologized to his dog.)

11 A Polish vampire.

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CHAPTER V

A WONDERFUL LIKENESS

That evening, there arrived from Gratz ¹² the grave, dark-faced son of a picture cleaner, with a horse and cart laden with two large packing cases, having many pictures in each. It was a journey of ten leagues, and whenever a messenger arrived at the manor-house from our little capital we would crowd about him in the hall to hear the news.

This arrival created quite a sensation in our secluded quarters. The cases remained in the hall, and the messenger was taken charge of by the servants until he had eaten his supper. Then, with assistants, and armed with hammer, ripping-chisel, and turnscrew, he met us in the hall, where we had assembled to witness the unpacking of the cases.

Carmilla sat looking listlessly on while the old pictures, nearly all portraits that had undergone the process of renovation, were brought to light. My mother was of an old Hungarian family, and most of these pictures, which were about to be restored to their places, had come to us through her.

My father had a list in his hand, from which he read as the artist rummaged out the corresponding numbers. I don't know that the pictures were very good, but they were, undoubtedly, very old, and some of them very curious also. They had, for the most part, the merit of being now seen by me for the first time; for the smoke and dust of time had all but obliterated them.

“There is a picture that I have not seen yet,” said my father. “In one corner, at the top of it, is the name, as well as I could read, *Marcia Karnstein* , and the date 1698; I am curious to see how it has turned out.”

I remembered it; it was a small picture, about a foot and a half high and nearly square, without a frame; but it was so blackened by age that I could not make it out.

The artist now produced it, with evident pride. It was quite beautiful and startling; it seemed to live. And it was the effigy of Carmilla!

“Carmilla, dear, here is an absolute miracle. Here you are, living, smiling, ready to speak, in this picture. Isn’t it beautiful, Papa? And see, even the little mole on her throat.”

My father laughed and said, “Certainly it is a wonderful likeness,” but he looked away and to my surprise seemed but little struck by it. He went on talking to the picture cleaner, who was also something of an artist and discoursed with intelligence about the portraits and other works that his art had just brought into light and color, while I was more and more lost in wonder the more I looked at the picture.

“Will you let me hang this picture in my room, Papa?” I asked.

“Certainly, dear,” said he, smiling. “I’m very glad you think it so like. It must be prettier even than I thought it, if it is.”

The young lady did not acknowledge this pretty speech, did not seem to hear it. She was leaning back in her seat, her fine eyes under their long lashes gazing on me in contemplation. She smiled in a kind of rapture.

“And now you can read quite plainly the name that is written in the corner,” I said. “It is not *Marcia* . It looks as if it was done in gold. The name is *Mircalla, Countess Karnstein* , and this is a little coronet over, and underneath, *A.D. 1698* . I am descended from the Karnsteins; that is, Mama was.”

“Ah!” said the lady, languidly, “so am I, I think, a very long descent, very ancient. Are there any Karnsteins living now?”

“None who bear the name, I believe. The family were ruined, I believe, in some civil wars, long ago, but the ruins of the castle are only about three miles away.”

“How interesting!” she said, languidly. “But see what beautiful moonlight!” She glanced through the hall door, which stood a little open. “Suppose you take a little ramble round the court and look down at the road and river.”

“It is so like the night you came to us,” I said.

She sighed, smiling. Then, she rose, and—each with an arm about the other’s waist—we walked out upon the pavement. In silence, slowly, we walked down to the drawbridge, where the beautiful landscape opened before us.

“And so you were thinking of the night I came here?” she almost whispered. “Are you glad I came?”

“Delighted, dear Carmilla,” I answered.

“And you asked for the picture you think like me, to hang in your room,” she murmured with a sigh, as she drew her arm closer about my waist and let her pretty head sink upon my shoulder.

“How romantic you are, Carmilla,” I said. “Whenever you tell me your story, it will be made up chiefly of some one great romance.”

She kissed me silently.



“I am sure, Carmilla, you have been in love; that there is, at this moment, an affair of the heart going on.”

“I have been in love with no one, and never shall,” she whispered, “unless it should be with you.” How beautiful she looked in the moonlight!

Shy and strange was the look with which she quickly hid her face in my neck and hair, with tumultuous sighs that almost turned to sobs. She pressed in mine a hand that trembled; her soft cheek was glowing against my own. “Darling, darling,” she murmured, “I live in you; and you would die for me, I love you so.”

I started from her. She was gazing on me with eyes from which all fire, all meaning had flown; her face was colorless and apathetic.

“Is there a chill in the air, dear?” she said drowsily. “I almost shiver; have I been dreaming? Let us come in. Come; come; come in.”

“You look ill, Carmilla; a little faint. You certainly must take some wine,” I said.

“Yes. I will. I’m better now. I shall be quite well in a few minutes. Yes, do give me a little wine,” answered Carmilla, as we approached the door. “Let us look again for a moment; it is the last time, perhaps, I shall see the moonlight with you.”

“How do you feel now, dear Carmilla? Are you really better?” I asked. I was beginning to take alarm, lest she should have been stricken with the strange epidemic that they said had invaded the country about us. “Papa would be grieved beyond measure,” I added, “if he thought you were ever so little ill, without immediately letting us know. We have a very skillful doctor near us, the physician who was with Papa today.”

“I’m sure he is. I know how kind you all are; but, dear child, I am quite well again. There is nothing ever wrong with me but a little weakness. People say I am languid; I am incapable of exertion; I can scarcely walk as far as a child of three years old; and every now and then the little strength I have falters, and I become as you have just seen me. But after all I am very easily set up again; in a moment I am perfectly myself. See how I have recovered.”

So, indeed, she had; and she and I talked a great deal, and very animated she was; and the remainder of that evening passed without any recurrence of what I called her infatuations. I mean her crazy talk and looks, which embarrassed and even frightened me.

But there occurred that night an event which gave my thoughts quite a new turn and seemed to startle even Carmilla’s languid nature into momentary energy.

CHAPTER VI

A VERY STRANGE AGONY

When we had returned to the drawing room and sat down to our coffee and chocolate—although Carmilla did not take any—she seemed quite herself again. Madame Perrodon and Mademoiselle De Lafontaine joined us and made a little card party, in the course of which Papa came in for what he called his “dish of tea.”

When the game was over he sat down beside Carmilla on the sofa and asked her, a little anxiously, whether she had heard from her mother since her arrival.

She answered, “No.”

He then asked whether she knew where a letter would reach her at present.

“I cannot tell,” she answered ambiguously, “but I have been thinking of leaving you; you have been already too hospitable and too kind to me. I have given you an infinity of trouble, and I should wish to take a carriage tomorrow and post in pursuit of her; I know where I shall ultimately find her, although I dare not yet tell you.”

“But you must not dream of any such thing,” exclaimed my father, to my great relief. “We can’t afford to lose you so, and I won’t consent to your leaving us except under the care of your mother, who was so good as to consent to your remaining with us until she should herself return. I should be quite happy if I knew that you heard from her; but this evening the accounts of the progress of the mysterious disease that

has invaded our neighborhood grow even more alarming; and, my beautiful guest, I do feel the responsibility, even unaided by advice from your mother. But I shall do my best, and one thing is certain: You must not think of leaving us without her distinct direction to that effect. We should suffer too much in parting from you to consent to it easily.”

“Thank you, sir, a thousand times for your hospitality,” she answered, smiling bashfully. “You have all been too kind to me; I have seldom been so happy in all my life before as in your beautiful château, under your care, and in the society of your dear daughter.”

So he gallantly, in his old-fashioned way, kissed her hand, smiling and pleased at her little speech.

I accompanied Carmilla as usual to her room and sat and chatted with her while she was preparing for bed.

“Do you think,” I said at length, “that you will ever confide fully in me?”

She turned around smiling but made no answer, only continued to smile at me.

“You won’t answer that?” I said. “You can’t answer pleasantly; I ought not to have asked you.”

“You were quite right to ask me that, or anything. You do not know how dear you are to me, or you could not think any confidence too great to look for. But I am under vows—no nun half so awfully—and I dare not tell my story yet, even to you. The time is very near when you shall know everything. You will think me cruel, very selfish, but love is always selfish; the more ardent the more selfish. How jealous I am you cannot know. You must come with me, loving me, to death; or else hate me and still come with me, *hating* me through death and after. There is no such word as indifference in my apathetic nature.”

“Now, Carmilla,” I said hastily, “Are you are going to talk your wild nonsense again?”

“Not I, silly little fool as I am, and full of whims and fancies; for your sake I’ll talk like a sage. Were you ever at a ball?”

“No; how you do run on. What is it like? How charming it must be.”

“I almost forget; it was years ago.”

I laughed. “You are not so old. Your first ball can hardly be forgotten yet.”

“I remember everything about it—with an effort. I see it all as divers see what is going on above them: through a medium dense and rippling, but transparent. What occurred that night has confused the picture and made its colors faint. I was all but assassinated in my bed, wounded here,” she touched her breast, “and never was the same since.”

“Were you near dying?”

“Yes, very—a cruel love, a strange love, that would have taken my life. Love will have its sacrifices. No sacrifice without blood. Let us go to sleep now; I feel so lazy. How can I get up just now and lock my door?”

She was lying with her tiny hands buried in the rich, wavy hair under her cheek, her little head upon the pillow, and her glittering eyes followed me wherever I moved, with a kind of shy smile that I could not decipher.

I bade her goodnight, and crept from the room with an uncomfortable sensation. I often wondered whether our pretty guest ever said her prayers. I certainly had never seen her upon her knees. In the morning she never came down until long after our family prayers were over, and at night she never left the drawing-room to attend our brief evening prayers in the hall. If not that it had casually come out in one of our careless talks that she had been baptized, I should have doubted her being a Christian. Religion was a subject on which I had never heard her speak a word. If I had known the world better, this particular neglect or antipathy would not have so much surprised me.

The precautions of nervous people are infectious, and persons of a like temperament are pretty sure, after a time, to imitate them. I had adopted Carmilla's habit of locking her bedroom door, having taken into my head all her whimsical alarms about midnight invaders and prowling assassins. I had also adopted her precaution of making a brief search through the room, to satisfy myself that no lurking assassin or robber was "ensconced." These wise measures taken, I got into my bed and fell asleep. A light was burning in my room. This was an old habit, of very early date, and nothing could have tempted me to dispense with it. Thus fortified, I would take my rest in peace.

But that night, dreams came through stone walls, and lit up dark rooms and darkened light ones. Their persons made their exits and their entrances as they pleased, and laughed at locksmiths. That night, I had a dream that was the beginning of a very strange agony.

I cannot call it a nightmare, for I was quite conscious of being asleep. But I was equally conscious of being in my room and lying in bed, precisely as I actually was. I saw, or fancied I saw, the room and its furniture just as I had seen it last, except that it was very dark, and I saw something moving round the foot of the bed, which at first I could not accurately distinguish.

But soon, I saw that it was a sooty-black animal that resembled a monstrous cat. It appeared to me about four or five feet long—it measured fully the length of the hearth-rug as it passed over it—and it continued toing and froing with the lithe, sinister restlessness of a beast in a cage. I could not cry out, although I was terrified. Its pace was growing faster, and the room rapidly darker and darker, at length so dark that I could no longer see anything of it but its eyes. I felt it spring lightly on the bed. The two broad eyes approached my face, and suddenly I felt a stinging pain as if two large needles darted, an inch or two apart, deep into my breast.

I woke with a scream. The room was lighted by the candle that burnt there all through the night, and I saw a female figure standing at the

foot of the bed. She was in a dark, loose dress, and her hair was down and covered her shoulders. There was not the slightest stir of respiration; a block of stone could not have been more still. As I stared at her, the figure appeared to change her place and was now nearer the door; then, close to it; the door opened, and she exited through it.

I was now relieved and able to breathe and move. My first thought was that Carmilla had been playing a trick on me and that I had forgotten to secure my door. I hastened to it and found it locked, as usual, on the inside. I was afraid to open it—I was horrified. I sprang into my bed and covered my head up in the bedclothes, and lay there more dead than alive until morning.

CHAPTER VII

DESCENDING

It would be vain my attempting to tell you the horror with which, even now, I recall the occurrence of that night. It was no such transitory terror as a dream leaves behind it. It seemed to deepen with time and communicate itself to the very room and furniture that had witnessed the apparition.

The next day, I could not bear to be alone for a moment. I would have told Papa but for two opposite reasons: I thought he would laugh at my story, and I could not bear its being treated as a jest; and I thought he might fancy that I had been attacked by the mysterious complaint which had invaded our neighborhood. I had myself no misgiving of the kind, and as he had been rather an invalid for some time, I was afraid of alarming him.

I was, however, comfortable enough with my good-natured companions, Madame Perrodon and the vivacious Mademoiselle De Lafontaine. They both perceived that I was out of spirits and nervous, and at length I told them what lay so heavy at my heart. Mademoiselle laughed, but Madame Perrodon looked anxious.

“By the way,” said Mademoiselle, laughing, “the long lime-tree walk, behind Carmilla’s bedroom window, is haunted!”

“Nonsense!” exclaimed Madame, who thought the theme rather inappropriate for breakfast. “Who tells that story, my dear?”

“Martin says that he came up twice before sunrise, when the old yard-gate was being repaired, and saw the same female figure walking down the lime-tree avenue.”

“So he would, as long as there are cows to milk in the river fields,” said Madame.

“I dare say; but Martin chooses to be frightened, and never did I see a fool *more* frightened.”

“You must not say a word about it to Carmilla, because she can see down that walk from her room window,” I interposed, “and she is, if possible, a greater coward than I.”

Carmilla came down rather later than usual that day.

“I was so frightened last night,” she said, so soon as we were together, “and I am sure I should have seen something dreadful if it had not been for that charm I bought from the poor little hunchback whom I called such hard names. I had a dream of something black coming round my bed, and I awoke in a perfect horror. I really thought, for some seconds, that I saw a dark figure near the chimney-piece, but I felt under my pillow for my charm; the moment my fingers touched it, the figure disappeared. I felt quite certain that, had it not been by me, something frightful would have made its appearance and perhaps throttled me, as it did those poor people we heard of.”

“Well, listen to me,” I began, and recounted my adventure, at the recital of which she appeared horrified.

“And was the charm near you?” she asked, earnestly.

“No, I had dropped it into a china vase in the drawing room. But I shall certainly take it with me tonight, as you have so much faith in it.”

At this distance of time I cannot tell you, or even understand, how I overcame my horror so capably as to lie alone in my room that night. I remember distinctly that I pinned the charm to my pillow. I fell asleep almost immediately and slept even more soundly than usual all night.

The next night I passed in the same way. My sleep was delightfully deep and dreamless. But I wakened with a pleasant, almost luxurious sense of lassitude and melancholy.

“Well, I told you so,” said Carmilla, when I described my quiet sleep. “I had such delightful sleep myself last night; I pinned the charm to the breast of my nightdress. It was too far away the night before. I am quite sure it was all fancy, except the dreams. I used to think that evil spirits made dreams, but our doctor told me it is no such thing. It is only that a fever or some other malady passing by knocks on the door—as they often do, he said—and, not being able to get in, passes on.”

“And what do you think the charm is?” I said.

“It has been fumigated or immersed in some drug and is an antidote against the malaria,” she answered.

“Then it acts only on the body?”

“Certainly; you don’t suppose that evil spirits are frightened by bits of ribbon or the perfumes of a druggist’s shop? No. These complaints, wandering in the air, begin by trying the nerves and so infect the brain. But before they can seize upon you, the antidote repels them. That I am sure is what the charm has done for us. It is nothing magical, it is simply natural.”

I should have been happier if I could have quite agreed with Carmilla; I did my best, but the impression was losing its force.

For some nights I slept profoundly, but still every morning I felt the same lassitude, and a languor weighed upon me all day. I felt myself a changed girl. A strange melancholy was stealing over me, a melancholy I would not have interrupted. Dim thoughts of death began to open, and an idea that I was slowly declining took gentle, and somehow not unwelcome, possession of me. If it was sad, the state of mind it induced was also sweet. Whatever it was, my soul acquiesced to it. I would not admit that I was ill, and I would not consent to tell my papa or to have the doctor sent for.

Carmilla became more devoted to me than ever, and her strange paroxysms of languid adoration more frequent. She doted on me with increasing ardor the more my strength and spirits waned. It shocked me, like a momentary glare of insanity.

Without knowing it, I was now in an advanced stage of the strangest illness under which any mortal had ever suffered. There was an unaccountable pleasure in its earlier symptoms that concealed from me the incapacitating effects of the malady. This fascination increased for a time, until it reached the point when a sense of the horrible mingled with it, deepening, as you shall hear, until it discolored and perverted the whole state of my life.

The first change I experienced was rather agreeable. It was very near the turning point from which began the descent of Avernus.¹³

Certain vague and strange sensations visited me in my sleep. The prevailing one was of that pleasant, peculiar cold thrill we feel while bathing, when we move against the current of a river. This was soon accompanied by dreams that seemed interminable and were so vague that I could never recollect their scenery and persons. But they left an awful impression and a sense of exhaustion, as if I had passed through a long period of great mental exertion and danger.

After all these dreams, there remained on waking a remembrance of having been in a place very nearly dark, and of having spoken to people whom I could not see. And, especially, of one clear voice, a woman's, very deep, that spoke as if at a distance, producing always the same sensation of indescribable solemnity and fear. Sometimes there came a sensation as if a hand was drawn softly along my cheek and neck. Sometimes it was as if warm lips kissed me, longer and longer and more lovingly as they reached my throat, and there the caress fixed itself. My heart beat faster, my breathing rose and fell rapidly; then came a sobbing that rose into a sense of strangulation and turned into a dreadful convulsion, in which my senses left me and I became unconscious.¹⁴

It was now three weeks since the commencement of this unaccountable state. My sufferings had, during the last week, told upon my appearance. I had grown pale. My eyes were dilated and darkened underneath, and the languor which I had long felt began to display itself in my countenance. My father asked me often whether I was ill; but, with an obstinacy which now seems to me unaccountable, I persisted in assuring him that I was quite well.

In a sense, this was true. I had no pain; I could complain of no bodily derangement. My complaint seemed to be one of the imagination or the nerves, and, horrible as my sufferings were, I kept them with a morbid reserve very nearly to myself. It could not be that terrible complaint which the peasants called the *oupire*, for I had now been suffering for three weeks, and they were seldom ill for much more than three days before death put an end to their miseries.

Carmilla complained, too, of dreams and feverish sensations, but by no means of so alarming a kind as mine. Mine were extremely alarming. Had I been capable of comprehending my condition, I would have invoked aid and advice on my knees. The narcotic of an unsuspected influence was acting upon me, and my perceptions were benumbed.

I am going to tell you now of a dream that led immediately to an odd discovery.

One night, instead of the voice I was accustomed to hear in the dark, I heard one—sweet and tender, and at the same time terrible—which said, “Your mother warns you to beware of the assassin.” At the same time a light unexpectedly sprang up, and I saw Carmilla standing near the foot of my bed in her white nightdress, bathed from her chin to her feet in one great stain of blood.



I woke with a shriek, certain that Carmilla was being murdered. I remember springing from my bed. My next recollection is standing in the hallway, crying for help. Madame and Mademoiselle came scurrying out of their rooms in alarm; a lamp burned always in that hallway and, seeing me, they soon learned the cause of my terror.

I insisted that we knock on Carmilla's door. Our knocking was unanswered. It soon became a pounding and then an uproar. We shrieked her name, but all was vain. We all grew frightened, for the door was locked, and hurried in a panic back to my room. There, we rang the bell long and furiously. If my father's room had been at that side of the house, we would have called him up at once to our aid. But,

alas! He was quite hard of hearing, and to reach him involved an excursion for which we none of us had courage.

Servants, however, soon came running up the stairs. I donned my dressing gown and slippers in the meantime, and my companions were similarly attired. Recognizing the voices of the steward and his men in the hallway, we exited together; and after repeating our fruitless summons at Carmilla's door, I ordered them to force the lock. They did so.

We stood, holding our lights aloft, in the doorway, and so stared into the room. We called her by name, but there was still no reply. We looked around. Everything was undisturbed. It was exactly in the state in which I had left it on bidding her goodnight. But Carmilla was gone.

13 A volcanic crater near Naples, Italy, historically believed to be the entrance to the underworld. The word means "without birds."

14 If this isn't an orgasm, nothing is.

CHAPTER VIII

SEARCH

At sight of the room—perfectly undisturbed except for our violent entrance—we began to cool a little and soon recovered our senses sufficiently to dismiss the men. It occurred to Mademoiselle that possibly Carmilla had been wakened by the uproar at her door and in a panic had jumped from her bed and hid herself in a cupboard or behind a curtain, from which she could not, of course, emerge until the steward and his men had withdrawn. We recommenced our search and began to call her name again.

It was all to no purpose. Our perplexity and agitation increased. We examined the windows, but they were secured. I implored of Carmilla, if she had concealed herself, to play this cruel trick no longer—to come out and to end our anxieties. But it was useless. I was by this time convinced that she was not in the room, nor in the dressing room, the door of which was still locked on this side. She could not have passed it. I was utterly puzzled. Had Carmilla discovered one of those secret passages which the old housekeeper said were known to exist in the manor-house? ¹⁵ The tradition of their exact situation had been lost. A little time would, no doubt, explain all—utterly perplexed as, for the present, we were.

It was past four o'clock, and I preferred passing the remaining hours of darkness in Madame's room. Daylight brought no solution of the difficulty.

The whole household, with my father at its head, was in a state of agitation the next morning. Every part of the château was searched. The grounds were explored. No trace of the missing lady could be discovered. The men prepared to drag the streams. My father was in distraction; what a tale to have to tell the poor girl's mother on her return! I, too, was almost beside myself, though my grief was quite of a different kind. The morning passed in alarm and excitement. It was now one o'clock, and still no tidings.

Returning to Carmilla's room, I found her standing at her dressing table. I was astounded. I could not believe my eyes. She beckoned me to her with her pretty finger, in silence. Her face expressed extreme fear.

I ran to her in an ecstasy of joy; I kissed and embraced her again and again. I ran to the bell and rang it vehemently, to bring others to the spot that they might relieve my father's anxiety.

"Dear Carmilla, what has become of you all this time? We have been in agonies of anxiety about you," I exclaimed. "Where have you been? How did you come back?"

"Last night has been a night of wonders," she said.

"For mercy's sake, explain all you can."

"It was past two last night," she said, "when I went to sleep as usual in my bed, with my doors locked—both that of the dressing room and that opening upon the hallway. My sleep was uninterrupted and, so far as I know, dreamless; but I woke just now on the sofa in the dressing room there, and I found the door between the rooms open and the other door forced. How could all this have happened without my being wakened? It must have been accompanied with a great deal of noise, and I am particularly easily wakened; and how could I have been carried out of my bed without my sleep having been interrupted, I who am startled by the slightest stir?"

By this time, Madame, Mademoiselle, my father, and a number of the servants were in the room. Carmilla was, of course, overwhelmed with inquiries, congratulations, and welcomes. She had but the one story to tell and seemed the least able of all the party to suggest any way of accounting for what had happened.

My father took a turn up and down the room, thinking. I saw Carmilla's eye follow him for a moment with a sly, dark glance.

When my father had sent the servants away—Mademoiselle having gone in search of a tincture of valerian and smelling salts—and there being no one now in the room with Carmilla except my father, Madame, and myself, he came to her, taking her hand very kindly. He led her to the sofa and sat down beside her.

“Will you forgive me, my dear, if I risk a conjecture and ask a question?”

“Who can have a better right?” she said. “Ask what you please, and I will tell you everything. But my story is simply one of bewilderment and darkness. I know absolutely nothing. Put any question you please. But you know, of course, the limitations Mama has placed me under.”

“Perfectly, my dear child. I need not approach the topics on which she desires our silence. Now, the marvel of last night consists in your having been removed from your bed and your room, without being wakened, and this removal having occurred apparently while the windows were still secured and the two doors locked upon the inside. I will tell you my theory. But first, I must ask you a question.”

Carmilla was leaning on her hand dejectedly; Madame and I were listening breathlessly.

“Now, my question is this. Have you ever been suspected of walking in your sleep?”

“Not since I was very young.”

“But you did walk in your sleep when you were young?”

“Yes, I know I did. I have been told so often by my old nurse.”

My father smiled and nodded. “Well, what has happened is this. You got up in your sleep and unlocked the door, not leaving the key, as usual, in the lock but taking it out and locking it on the outside. You again took the key out and carried it away with you to some one of the five-and-twenty rooms on this floor, or perhaps upstairs or downstairs. There are so many rooms and closets, so much heavy furniture, and such accumulations of lumber, that it would require a week to search this old house thoroughly. Do you see, now, what I mean?”

“I do, but not all,” she answered.

“And how, Papa, do you account for her finding herself on the sofa in the dressing room, which we had searched so carefully?” I said.

“She came there after you had searched it, still in her sleep, and at last awoke spontaneously and was as much surprised to find herself where she was as anyone else. I wish all mysteries were as easily and innocently explained as yours, Carmilla,” he said, laughing. “And so we may congratulate ourselves on the certainty that the most natural explanation of the occurrence is one that involves no drugging, no tampering with locks, no burglars or poisoners or witches—nothing that need alarm Carmilla, or anyone else, for our safety.”

Carmilla looked radiant and charming. Nothing could be more beautiful than her coloring. Her beauty was, I think, enhanced by that graceful languor that was peculiar to her. I think my father was silently contrasting her looks with mine, for he said, “I wish my poor Laura was looking more like herself,” and he sighed.

So our alarms were happily ended, and Carmilla restored to her friends.

15 Half a century before, a serving girl followed the sound of a baby crying into one of those passages, the entrance of which was hidden behind a particularly gruesome tapestry of Leda and the Swan. It is said that when her eyes adjusted to the darkness, she saw a figure crouched against the stone wall, holding a swaddled mass. When the figure looked up, the serving girl reported, its face was her own. (“Not an uncanny likeness, as of a sister, but stolen from me.”) As for the bundle in its arms: When the figure stood to its full height, the blanket fell open and

nothing was there. The serving girl was found by her screams; the family was kind enough to pay for the many doctors and priests who would eventually attend her bedside.

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CHAPTER IX

THE DOCTOR

As Carmilla would not hear of an attendant sleeping beside her, my father arranged that a servant should sleep outside her room, so that she would not attempt to make another such excursion without being arrested at her own door.

That night passed quietly; and next morning early, the doctor, for whom my father had sent in secret, arrived to see me.

Madame accompanied me to the library. There the grave little doctor, with his white hair and spectacles, was waiting to receive me.

I told him my story, and as I proceeded he grew graver and graver.

We were standing, he and I, in the recess of one of the windows, facing one another. When my statement was over, he leaned with his shoulders against the wall. His eyes were fixed on me with interest, in which resided a dash of horror. After a minute's reflection, he asked Madame if he could see my father.

My father was sent for accordingly, and as he entered, smiling, he said, "I dare say, doctor, you are going to tell me that I am an old fool for having brought you here; I hope I am."

But his smile faded into shadow as the doctor, with his very grave face, beckoned him.

He and the doctor talked for some time in the same recess where I had just conferred with the physician. It seemed an earnest and argumentative conversation. The room was very large, and I and

Madame stood together burning with curiosity at the further end. Not a word could we hear, however, for they spoke in a very low tone, and the depth of the window concealed the doctor from view and very nearly concealed my father, whose foot, arm, and shoulder were all we could see. Their voices were, I suppose, all the less audible for the sort of closet which the thick wall and window formed.

After a time my father's face looked into the room; it was pale, thoughtful, and, I noticed, agitated.

"Laura, dear, come here for a moment," he said. "Madame, we don't need you at present."

I approached, for the first time a little alarmed. Although I felt very weak, I did not feel ill; and strength, one always fancies, is a thing that may be picked up when we please.

My father held out his hand to me as I drew near, but he was looking at the doctor.

"It certainly is very odd; I don't understand it," he said. "Laura, come here, dear; now attend to Doctor Spielsberg and recollect yourself."

"You mentioned a sensation like that of two needles piercing the skin, somewhere about your neck, on the night when you experienced your first horrible dream," the doctor said. "Is there still any soreness?"

"None at all," I answered.

"Can you indicate with your finger about the point at which you think this occurred?"

"Very little below my throat—*here*," I answered. I wore a morning dress, which covered the place I pointed to.

"Now you can satisfy yourself," said the doctor. "You won't mind your papa's lowering your dress a very little. It is necessary, to detect a symptom of the complaint under which you have been suffering."

I acquiesced. It was only an inch or two below the edge of my collar.

“God bless me! So it is,” exclaimed my father, growing pale.

“You see it now with your own eyes,” said the doctor with a gloomy triumph.

“What is it?” I whimpered, beginning to be frightened.

“Nothing, my dear young lady, but a small blue spot, about the size of the tip of your little finger. And now,” he continued, turning to papa, “the question is, what is best to be done?”

“Is there any danger?” I asked with trepidation.

“I trust not, my dear,” answered the doctor. “I don’t see why you should not recover. I don’t see why you should not begin *immediately* to get better. That is the point at which the sense of strangulation begins?”

“Yes,” I answered.

“And—recollect as well as you can—the same point was a kind of center of that thrill which you described just now, like the current of a cold stream running against you?”

“It may have been; I think it was.”

“Ah, you see?” he added, turning to my father. “Shall I say a word to Madame?”

“Certainly,” said my father.

He called Madame to him and said: “I find my young friend here far from well. It won’t be of any great consequence, I hope, but it will be necessary that some steps be taken, which I will explain by and by; in the meantime, Madame, you will be so good as not to let Miss Laura be alone for one moment. That is the only direction I need give for the present. It is indispensable.”

“We may rely upon your kindness, Madame, I know,” added my father.

Madame nodded in agreement.

“And you, dear Laura, I know you will observe the doctor’s direction.”

“I shall have to ask your opinion upon another patient,” my father continued, “whose symptoms slightly resemble those of my daughter, which have just been detailed to you—very much milder in degree, but I believe of the same sort. She is a young lady—our guest. As you say you will be passing this way again this evening, you can’t do better than take your supper here, and you can then see her. She does not come down till the afternoon.”

“I thank you,” said the doctor. “I shall return, then, at about seven this evening.”

And then they repeated their directions to me and to Madame, and with this parting charge my father left us and walked out with the doctor; and I saw them pacing together up and down between the road and the moat, on the grassy platform in front of the house, evidently absorbed in earnest conversation.

The doctor did not return. I saw him mount his horse there, take his leave, and ride away eastward through the forest. Soon after, I saw the man arrive from the village with letters. He dismounted and handed the bag to my father.

In the meantime, Madame and I were both busy, lost in conjecture as to the reasons of the singular and earnest directions the doctor and my father had given us. Madame, as she afterwards told me, was afraid the doctor suspected an oncoming seizure, and that without prompt assistance I might either lose my life in a fit or at least be seriously hurt.

The interpretation did not sit well with me. I fancied—perhaps luckily for my nerves—that the arrangement was prescribed simply to secure a companion who would prevent my taking too much exercise or eating unripe fruit or doing any of the fifty foolish things to which young people are supposed to be prone.

About half an hour afterward, my father came in, a letter in his hand, and said: “This letter had been delayed; it is from General

Spielsdorf. He might have been here yesterday—he may not come till tomorrow, or he may be here today.”

He put the open letter into my hand but he did not look pleased as he used to when a guest, especially one so much loved as the general, was coming. On the contrary, he looked as if he wished him at the bottom of the Red Sea. There was plainly something on his mind which he did not choose to divulge.

“Papa, darling, will you tell me something?” I said, laying my hand on his arm and looking imploringly in his face.

“Perhaps,” he answered, smoothing my hair over my eyes.

“Does the doctor think me very ill?”

“No, dear; he thinks that if the right steps are taken, you will be quite well again—or at least on the high road to a complete recovery—in a day or two,” he answered, a little dryly. “I wish our good friend, the general, had chosen any other time. That is, I wish you had been perfectly well to receive him.”

“But do tell me, Papa,” I insisted, “*what* does he think is the matter with me?”

“Nothing; you must not plague me with questions,” he answered, with more irritation than I ever remember him to have displayed before. Seeing that I looked wounded, he kissed me and added, “You shall know all about it in a day or two; that is, all that *I* know. In the meantime you are not to trouble your head about it.”

He turned and left the room but came back before I had done wondering and puzzling over the oddity of all this; it was merely to say that he was going to Karnstein and had ordered the carriage to be ready at twelve, and that I and Madame should accompany him. He was going to see the priest who lived near those picturesque grounds for business, and—as Carmilla had never seen them—she could follow later with Mademoiselle, who would bring materials for a picnic, which might be laid for us in the ruined castle.

At twelve o'clock, accordingly, I was ready, and not long after, my father, Madame, and I set out upon our drive. Passing the drawbridge, we turned to the right and followed the road over the steep Gothic bridge, westward, to reach the deserted village and ruined castle of Karnstein.

No sylvan drive was prettier. The ground broke into gentle hills and hollows, all clothed with beautiful wood, empty of the formality of artificial planting and pruning.¹⁶ The irregularities of the earth often turned the road from its course and caused it to wind beautifully round the sides of broken hollows and the steeper sides of the hills. Turning one of these points, we encountered our old friend, the general, riding towards us, attended by a mounted servant. His many trunks followed in a hired wagon.

The general dismounted as we pulled up and, after the usual greetings, was easily persuaded to join us. He sent his horse on with his servant to the manor-house and accepted the vacant seat in our carriage.

¹⁶ Lonely as she was, if only Laura knew the potential friends who resided in those woods! Peddlers, mountebanks, roguish-but-decent thieves and brigands, fairies, wolpertingers, spirits, two different species of elves, the ghost of the serving girl who used to live in the manor-house (searching for herself), talking deer, sentient boulders, tree-spirits, rock-spirits, river-spirits, soil-spirits, two hermits, and an adolescent Tatzelwurm.

CHAPTER X

BEREAVED

It was about ten months since we had last seen him—but that time had sufficed to make an alteration of years in his appearance. He had grown thinner; gloom and anxiety had taken the place of the cordial serenity that used to characterize his features. His dark blue eyes, always penetrating, now gleamed with a sterner light from under his shaggy grey eyebrows. It was not such a change as grief alone usually induces; it suggested angrier passions.

We had not long resumed our drive when the general began to talk, with his usual soldierly directness, of the bereavement—as he termed it—which he had sustained in the death of his beloved niece and ward. He then broke out in a tone of intense bitterness and fury, inveighing against the “hellish arts” to which she had fallen a victim and expressing, with more exasperation than piety, his wonder that heaven should tolerate so monstrous an indulgence of the lusts and malignity of hell.

My father, who saw at once that something very extraordinary had befallen, asked him—if it were not too painful for him—to detail the circumstances that justified the strong terms in which he expressed himself.

“I should tell you all with pleasure,” said the general, “but you would not believe me.”

“Why should I not?” he asked.

“Because,” he answered testily, “you believe in nothing but what consists with your own prejudices and illusions. I remember when I was like you, but I have learned better.”

“Try me,” said my father. “I am not such a dogmatist as you suppose. Besides which, I very well know that you generally require proof for what you believe and am, therefore, very strongly predisposed to respect your conclusions.”

“You are right in supposing that I have not been led lightly into a belief in the marvelous—for what I have experienced is marvelous—and I have been forced by extraordinary evidence to credit that which ran counter to all my theories. I have been made the dupe of an otherworldly conspiracy.”

Notwithstanding his professions of confidence in the general’s beliefs, I saw my father glance at him with a marked suspicion of his sanity.

The general did not see it, luckily. He was looking gloomily and curiously into the glades and vistas of the woods that were opening before us.

“You are going to the ruins of Karnstein?” he said. “It is a lucky coincidence; do you know I was going to ask you to bring me there to inspect them? I have a special object I am interested in exploring. There is a ruined chapel, isn’t there, with a great many tombs of that extinct family?”

“So there are—highly interesting,” said my father. “I hope you are thinking of claiming the title and estates?” My father said this gaily, but the general did not laugh or even smile at his friend’s joke; on the contrary, he looked grave and even fierce, ruminating on a matter that stirred his anger and horror.

“Something very different,” he said, gruffly. “I mean to unearth some of those fine people. I hope, by God’s blessing, to accomplish a pious sacrilege here, which will relieve our earth of certain monsters and enable honest people to sleep in their beds without being assailed

by murderers. I have strange things to tell you, my dear friend. Things that I myself would have doubted a few months ago."

My father looked at him again, but this time not with a glance of suspicion—with an eye, rather, of keen intelligence and alarm. "The house of Karnstein," he said, "has been long extinct: a hundred years at least. My dear wife was maternally descended from the Karnsteins. But the name and title have long ceased to exist. The castle is a ruin; the village is deserted; it is fifty years since the smoke of a chimney was seen there. There is not a roof left."

"Quite true. I have heard a great deal about that since I last saw you, a great deal that will astonish you. But I best relate everything in the order in which it occurred," said the general. "You saw my dear ward—my child, I may call her. No creature could have been more beautiful, and only three months ago none more blooming."

"Yes, poor thing! when I saw her last she certainly was quite lovely," said my father. "I was grieved and shocked more than I can tell you, my dear friend; I know what a blow it was to you." He took the general's hand and they exchanged a kind pressure.

Tears gathered in the old soldier's eyes. He did not seek to conceal them. He said: "We have been very old friends; I knew you would feel for me, childless as I am. She had become an object of devotion to me and repaid my care by an affection that cheered my home and made my life happy. That is all gone. The years that remain to me on earth may not be very long, but by God's mercy I hope to accomplish a service to mankind before I die. That is, to deliver the vengeance of heaven upon the fiends who have murdered my poor child in the spring of her hopes and beauty!"

"You said, just now, that you intended relating everything as it occurred," said my father. "Pray do; I assure you that it is not mere curiosity that prompts me."

By this time we had reached the point at which the Drunstall road, by which the general had come, diverged from the road which we were

traveling to Karnstein.

“How far is it to the ruins?” inquired the general, looking anxiously forward.

“About half a league,” answered my father. “Pray, let us hear the story you promised.”

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CHAPTER XI

THE STORY

“With all my heart,” said the general with an effort. After a short pause, he commenced one of the strangest narratives I ever heard.

“My dear child was looking forward with great pleasure to the visit you had been so good as to arrange for her to your charming daughter.” Here he made me a gallant but melancholy bow. “In the meantime, we had an invitation to my old friend the Count Carlsfeld, whose manor-house is about six leagues to the other side of Karnstein. It was to attend the series of balls which, you remember, he gave in honor of his illustrious visitor, the Grand Duke Charles.”

“Yes; and very splendid they were, I believe,” said my father.

“Princely! But then his hospitalities are quite regal. He has Aladdin’s lamp. The night from which my sorrow dates was devoted to a magnificent masquerade. The grounds were thrown open, the trees hung with colored lamps. There was such a display of fireworks as Paris itself had never witnessed. And such music—music, you know, is my weakness—such ravishing music! The finest instrumental band, perhaps in the world, and the finest singers who could be collected from all the great operas in Europe. As you wandered through these fantastically illuminated grounds, the moonlit château throwing a rosy glow from its long rows of windows, you would suddenly hear these ravishing voices stealing from the silence of some grove or rising from

boats upon the lake. I felt myself, as I looked and listened, carried back into the romance and poetry of my early youth.

“When the fireworks ended and the ball began, we returned to the noble suite of rooms that were thrown open to the dancers. A masked ball, you know, is a beautiful sight, but so brilliant a spectacle of the kind I never saw before. It was a very aristocratic assembly. I was myself almost the only ‘nobody’ present.

“My dear child was looking quite beautiful. She wore no mask. Her excitement and delight added an unspeakable charm to her features, always lovely. I noticed a young lady, dressed magnificently but wearing a mask, who appeared to me to be observing my ward with extraordinary interest. I had seen her earlier in the evening in the great hall and later, for a few minutes, walking near us on the terrace under the castle windows. A lady—also masked—richly and gravely dressed, and with the stately air of a person of rank, accompanied her as a chaperone. Had the young lady not worn a mask, I could, of course, have been much more certain upon the question whether she was really watching my poor darling. I am now well assured that she was.

“We were now in one of the parlors. My poor dear child had been dancing and was resting a little in one of the chairs near the door. I was standing near. The two ladies I have mentioned had approached, and the younger took the chair next my ward, while her companion stood beside me and for a little time addressed herself, in a low tone, to her charge.

“Availing herself of the privilege of her mask, she turned to me and, in the tone of an old friend and calling me by my name, opened a conversation with me. It piqued my curiosity a good deal. She referred to many times she had met me—at court, and at distinguished houses. She alluded to little incidents I had long forgotten, but which, I found, had only lain dormant in my memory, for they instantly started into life at her touch.

“I became more and more curious to ascertain who she was, every moment. She parried my attempts to discover very adroitly and pleasantly. The knowledge she showed of many passages in my life seemed to me all but unaccountable,¹⁷ and she appeared to take pleasure in foiling my curiosity and in seeing me flounder, in my eager perplexity, from one conjecture to another.

“In the meantime the young lady—whom her mother called by the odd name of Millarca—had, with the same ease and grace, begun a conversation with my ward.

“She introduced herself by saying that her mother was a very old acquaintance of mine. She spoke of the agreeable audacity which a mask rendered practical; she talked like a friend; she admired her dress and insinuated very prettily her admiration of her beauty. She amused her with laughing criticisms upon the people who crowded the ballroom and laughed at my poor child’s fun. She was very witty and lively when she pleased, and after a time they had grown very good friends, and the young stranger lowered her mask, displaying a remarkably beautiful face. I had never seen it before; neither had my dear child. But though it was new to us, the features were so engaging, as well as lovely, that it was impossible not to feel the attraction powerfully. My poor girl did so. I never saw anyone more taken with another at first sight, unless, indeed, it was the stranger herself, who seemed quite to have lost her heart to her.

“In the meantime, availing myself of the license of a masquerade, I put questions to the elder lady.

“‘You have puzzled me utterly,’ I said, laughing. ‘Is that not enough? Won’t you, now, consent to stand on equal terms and do me the kindness to remove your mask?’

“‘Can any request be more unreasonable?’ she replied. ‘Ask a lady to yield an advantage! Besides, how do you know you should recognize me? Years make changes.’

“‘As you see,’ I said, with a bow and a melancholy little laugh.

“‘As philosophers tell us,’ she said. ‘And how do you know that a sight of my face would help you?’

“‘I should take chance for that,’ I answered. ‘It is vain trying to make yourself out an old woman; your figure betrays you.’

“‘Years, nevertheless, have passed since I saw you—rather, since you saw me, for that is what I am considering. Millarca is my daughter; I therefore cannot be young, even in the opinion of people whom time has taught to be indulgent, and I may not like to be compared with what you remember of me. You have no mask to remove. You can offer me nothing in exchange.’

“‘My petition is to your pity, to remove it.’

“‘And mine to yours, to let it stay where it is,’ she replied.

“‘Well, then, at least you will tell me whether you are French or German; you speak both languages so perfectly.’

“‘I don’t think I shall tell you that, general; you intend a surprise and are meditating the particular point of attack.’

“‘In any event, you won’t deny this,’ I said. ‘Being honored by your permission to converse, I ought to know how to address you. Shall I say Madame la Comtesse?’

“‘She laughed, and she would, no doubt, have met me with another evasion—if, indeed, I can treat any occurrence in an interview that must have been prearranged with the profoundest cunning as liable to be modified by accident.

“‘As to that,’ she began—but she was interrupted, almost as she opened her lips, by a gentleman dressed in black. He looked particularly elegant and distinguished, with this drawback: His face was the deadliest pale I ever saw, except in death. He was in no masquerade—in the plain evening dress of a gentleman; and he said, without a smile but with a courtly and unusually low bow: ‘Will Madame la Comtesse permit me to say a very few words which may interest her?’ The demeanor of this gentleman was such as to impress

me with the conviction that the countess was a lady of very much more importance than her modest title alone might have led me to assume.

“The lady turned quickly to him and touched her finger to her lip in a gesture of silence. Then she said to me, ‘Keep my place for me, General; I shall return when I have said a few words.’

“And with this injunction playfully given, she walked a little aside with the gentleman in black and talked for some minutes, apparently very earnestly. They then walked away slowly together in the crowd, and I lost them for some minutes.

“I spent the interval wracking my brains for a hint as to the identity of the lady who seemed to remember me so kindly. I was thinking of turning and joining in the conversation between my pretty ward and the countess’s daughter, and trying to have a surprise in store for her when she returned by having her name, title, château, and estates at my fingers’ ends. But at this moment she came back, accompanied by the pale man in black, who said, ‘I shall return and inform Madame la Comtesse when her carriage is at the door.’ He withdrew with a bow.”

¹⁷ Though he does not say so here, the mysterious woman in fact laid bare one of the general’s greatest and most hidden secrets: his lover, Kurt, whom he had served with decades before. Not only did she know of Kurt’s existence and of the dimensions of their relationship, she knew the words Kurt had said to him in parting, which he had softly dropped into the shell of his ear: “I already miss our season.”

CHAPTER XII

A PETITION

The general continued.

“‘Then we are to lose Madame la Comtesse, but I hope only for a few hours,’ I said, with a low bow.

“‘It may be that only, or it may be a few weeks. It was very unlucky his speaking to me just now as he did. Do you now recognize me?’

“I assured her I did not.

“‘You shall,’ she said, ‘but not at present. We are older and better friends than, perhaps, you suspect. I cannot yet declare myself. I shall in three weeks pass your beautiful manor-house, about which I have been making enquiries. I shall then look in upon you for an hour or two and renew our friendship, which I never think of without a thousand pleasant recollections.

“‘But just now, a piece of news has reached me like a thunderbolt. I must set out and travel by a devious route, nearly a hundred miles, with all the speed I can possibly muster. My perplexities multiply. I am only deterred by my secrecy from making a very singular request of you. My poor child has not quite recovered her strength. Her horse fell with her at a recent hunt; her nerves have not yet recovered from the shock. Our physician says that she must on no account exert herself for some time to come. We came here in very easy stages—hardly six leagues a day. I must now travel day and night on a mission of life and death—a mission the critical and momentous nature of which I shall be

able to explain to you when we meet in a few weeks, without the necessity of any concealment.'

"She went on to make her petition, and it was in the tone of a person from whom such a request amounted to conferring, rather than seeking a favor. But this was only in manner. Except for the terms in which it was expressed, nothing could be more rueful. It was simply that I would consent to take charge of her daughter during her absence.

"This was, all things considered, a strange and audacious request. She in some sort disarmed me by stating and admitting everything that could be urged against it and throwing herself entirely upon my chivalry. At the same moment, by a fatality that seems to have predetermined all that happened, my poor child came to my side and, in an undertone, besought me to invite her new friend, Millarca, to pay us a visit. She had just been asking her and thought, if her mama would allow her, she would like it extremely.

"At another time I should have told her to wait a little, until, at least, we knew who they were. But I had not a moment to think in. The two ladies assailed me together, and I must confess the refined and beautiful face of the young lady, about which there was something extremely engaging, as well as the elegance and fire of high birth, overpowered me. I submitted and undertook too easily the care of the young lady, whom her mother called Millarca.

"The countess beckoned to her daughter, who listened with grave attention while she told her, in general terms, how suddenly and peremptorily she had been summoned, and also of the arrangement she had made for her under my care, adding that I was one of her earliest and most valued friends.

"I made, of course, such speeches as the case seemed to call for, and found myself, on reflection, in a position which I did not like.

"The gentleman in black returned and very ceremoniously conducted the lady from the room.

“Her last charge to me was that no attempt was to be made to learn more about her than I might already have guessed, not until her return. The ball’s distinguished host, whose guest she was, knew her reasons.

“‘But here,’ she said, ‘neither I nor my daughter could safely remain for more than a day. I removed my mask imprudently for a moment about an hour ago, and, too late, I thought you saw me. So I resolved to find an opportunity to talk to you. Had I found that you *had* seen me, I would have thrown myself on your high sense of honor to keep my secret some weeks. As it is, I am satisfied that you did not see me; but if you now *suspect* or, on reflection, *should* suspect, who I am, I commit myself entirely to your honor. My daughter will observe the same secrecy, and I well know that you will, from time to time, remind her, lest she should thoughtlessly disclose it.’

“She whispered a few words to her daughter, kissed her hurriedly twice, and went away, accompanied by the pale gentleman in black, and disappeared in the crowd.

“‘In the next room,’ said Millarca, ‘there is a window that looks upon the hall door. I should like to see the last of Mama and to kiss my hand to her.’

“We assented, of course, and accompanied her to the window. We looked out and saw a handsome old-fashioned carriage with a troop of couriers and footmen. We saw the slim figure of the pale gentleman in black bearing a thick velvet cloak; he placed it about her shoulders and threw the hood over her head. She nodded to him and touched his hand with hers. He bowed low and repeatedly as the door closed, and the carriage began to move.

“‘She is gone,’ said Millarca with a sigh.

“‘She is gone,’ I repeated to myself, reflecting for the first time—in the hurried moments that had elapsed since my consent—upon the folly of my act.

“‘She did not look up,’ said the young lady, plaintively.

“‘The countess had taken off her mask, perhaps, and did not care to show her face,’ I said; ‘she could not know that you were in the window.’

“She sighed and looked in my face. She was so beautiful that I relented. I was sorry I had for a moment repented of my hospitality and was determined to make her amends for the unfair discourtesy of my reception.

“The young lady, replacing her mask, joined my ward in persuading me to return to the grounds, where the concert was soon to be renewed. We did so, and walked up and down the terrace beneath the castle windows. Millarca became very intimate with us and amused us with lively descriptions and stories of most of the great people whom we saw upon the terrace. I liked her more and more every minute. Her gossip, without being ill-natured, was extremely entertaining to me. I had been so long out of the great world. I thought what life she would give to our lonely evenings at home.

“This ball was not over until the morning sun had almost reached the horizon. It pleased the Grand Duke to dance until then, so loyal people could not go away or even think of bed.

“We had just made our way through a crowded parlor when my ward asked me what had become of Millarca. I thought she had been by her side, and she fancied she was by mine. The fact was, we had lost her.

“All my efforts to find her were vain. I feared that she had mistaken, in the confusion of a momentary separation from us, other people for her new friends, and had pursued and lost them in the extensive grounds which were thrown open to us.

“Now, in its full force, I recognized the folly of having undertaken the charge of a young lady without so much as knowing her name. Fettered as I was by promises—the reasons for which were unknown to me—I could not even point my inquiries by saying that the missing

young lady was the daughter of the countess who had taken her departure a few hours before.

“Morning broke. It was clear daylight before I gave up my search. It was not till near two o’clock the next day that we heard anything of my missing charge.

“At about that time a servant knocked at my niece’s door, to say that he had been earnestly requested by a young lady, who appeared to be in great distress, to make out where she could find the General Baron Spielsdorf and the young lady his daughter, in whose charge she had been left by her mother.

“There could be no doubt, notwithstanding the slight inaccuracy, that our young friend had turned up; and so she had. If only we had lost her!

“She told my poor child a story to account for her having failed to recover us for so long. Very late, she said, she had got to the housekeeper’s bedroom in despair of finding us and had then fallen into a deep sleep which, long as it was, had hardly sufficed to recruit her strength after the fatigues of the ball.

“That day Millarca came home with us. I was only too happy, after all, to have secured so charming a companion for my dear girl.”

CHAPTER XIII

THE WOODMAN

“There soon, however, appeared some drawbacks. In the first place, Millarca complained of extreme languor—the weakness that remained after her late illness—and she never emerged from her room till the afternoon was pretty far advanced. In the next place, it was accidentally discovered that—although she always locked her door on the inside and never disturbed the key from its place till she admitted the maid to assist at her toilet—she was undoubtedly sometimes absent from her room in the very early morning and at various times later in the day, before she wished it to be understood that she was stirring. She was repeatedly seen from the windows of the manor-house in the first faint grey of the morning, walking through the trees in an easterly direction, looking like a person in a trance. This convinced me that she walked in her sleep. But this hypothesis did not solve the puzzle. How did she pass out from her room, leaving the door locked on the inside? How did she escape from the house without unbarring door or window?

“In the midst of my perplexities, an anxiety of a far more urgent kind presented itself.

“My dear child began to lose her looks and health, and that in a manner so mysterious, and even horrible, that I became thoroughly frightened.

“She was at first visited by appalling dreams; then, as she fancied, by a specter, sometimes resembling Millarca, sometimes in the shape of a beast, indistinctly seen, walking round the foot of her bed. Lastly came the sensations. One, not unpleasant but very peculiar, she said, resembled the flow of an icy stream against her breast. At a later time, she felt something like a pair of large needles pierce her painfully, a little below the throat. A few nights after there followed a gradual and convulsive sense of strangulation; then came unconsciousness.”

I could hear distinctly every word the kind old general was saying, because by this time we were driving upon the short grass that spreads on either side of the road as you approach the roofless village which had not shown the smoke of a chimney for more than half a century.

You may guess how strangely I felt to hear my own symptoms described so exactly in those which had been experienced by the poor girl who, but for the catastrophe which followed, would have been at that moment a visitor at my father’s château. You may suppose, also, how I felt as I heard him detail habits and mysterious peculiarities which were, in fact, those of our beautiful guest, Carmilla!

A vista opened in the forest; we were on a sudden under the chimneys and gables of the ruined village and the towers and battlements of the dismantled castle, around which gigantic trees were grouped, hanging over us from a slight slope.

In a frightened dream I got down from the carriage, and in silence—for we had each abundant matter for thinking—we soon mounted the ascent and were among the spacious chambers, winding stairs, and dark corridors of the castle.

“So this was once the palatial residence of the Karnsteins!” said the old general at length, as from a great window he looked out across the village and saw the wide, undulating expanse of forest. “It was a bad family, and here its bloodstained annals were written,” he continued. “It is hard that they should, after death, continue to plague the human

race with their atrocious lusts. That is the chapel of the Karnsteins, down there.”

He pointed down to the grey walls of the gothic building, partly visible through the foliage, a little way down the steep. “And I hear the axe of a woodman,” he added, “busy among the trees that surround it; he possibly may give us the information of which I am in search and point out the grave of Mircalla, Countess of Karnstein. These rustics preserve the local traditions of great families, whose stories die out among the rich and titled so soon as the families themselves become extinct.”

“We have a portrait, at home, of Mircalla, the Countess Karnstein; should you like to see it?” asked my father.

“Time enough, dear friend,” replied the General. “I believe that I have seen the original; and one motive which has led me to you earlier than I at first intended was to explore the chapel we are now approaching.”

“What! See the Countess Mircalla?” exclaimed my father. “Why, she has been dead more than a century!”

“Not so dead as you fancy, I am told,” answered the general.

“I confess, General, you puzzle me utterly,” replied my father, looking at him for a moment with a return of the suspicion I detected before. But although there was anger and detestation at times in the old general’s manner, there was nothing flighty.

“There remains to me,” he said, as we passed under the heavy arch of the gothic church—its dimensions justified its being so styled—“but one object which can interest me during the few years that remain to me on earth, and that is to wreak on her the vengeance which, I thank God, may still be accomplished by a mortal arm.”

“What vengeance can you mean?” asked my father, in increasing amazement.

“I mean, to decapitate the monster,” he answered with a fierce flush and a stomp that echoed mournfully through the hollow ruin. His

clenched hand was at the same moment raised, as if it grasped the handle of an axe; he shook it ferociously in the air.

“What?” exclaimed my father, more than ever bewildered.

“To strike her head off.”

“Cut her head off?”

“Aye, with a hatchet, with a spade, or with anything that can cleave through her murderous throat. You shall hear,” he answered, trembling with rage. And hurrying forward he said: “That beam will serve as a seat; your dear child is fatigued. Let her rest, and I will, in a few sentences, close my dreadful story.”

The squared block of wood, which lay on the grass-grown pavement of the chapel, formed a bench on which I was very glad to sit myself, and in the meantime the general called to the woodman, who had been removing some boughs that leaned upon the old walls.

Axe in hand, the hardy old fellow appeared before us. He could not tell us anything of these monuments, but there was an old man, he said, a ranger of this forest, at present sojourning in the house of the priest, about two miles away, who could point out every monument of the old Karnstein family. For a pittance he could bring him to us, if we would lend him one of our horses, in little more than half an hour.

“Have you been long employed about this forest?” asked my father of the old man.

“I have been a woodman here,” he answered in his patois, “all my days. So was my father before me, and so on, as many generations as I can count. I could show you the very house in the village in which my ancestors lived.”

“How came the village to be deserted?” asked the general.

“It was troubled by revenants, ¹⁸ sir; several were tracked to their graves and extinguished in the usual ways: by decapitation, by the stake, and by burning. But not until many of the villagers were killed.

“But even after all those proceedings,” he continued, “with so many graves opened and so many vampires deprived of their horrible

animation, the village was not relieved. But a Moravian¹⁹ nobleman, who happened to be traveling this way, heard how matters were, and being skilled in such affairs—as many people are in his country—he offered to deliver the village from its tormentor.

“He did so thus: There being a bright moon that night, he ascended, shortly after sunset, the towers of the chapel here, from whence he could distinctly see the churchyard beneath him; you can see it from that window. From this point he watched until he saw the vampire come out of his grave and place near it the linen clothes in which he had been folded, and then glide away towards the village to plague its inhabitants.

“The stranger, having seen all this, came down from the steeple, took the linen wrappings of the vampire, and carried them up to the top of the tower, which he again mounted. When the vampire returned from his prowling and missed his clothes, he cried furiously to the Moravian, whom he saw at the summit of the tower, and who, in reply, beckoned him to ascend and take them. Accepting his invitation, the vampire began to climb the steeple; and as soon as he had reached the battlements, the Moravian, with a stroke of his sword, clove his skull in twain, hurling him down to the churchyard, whither, descending by the winding stairs, the stranger followed and cut his head off, and next day delivered it and the body to the villagers, who duly impaled and burnt them.

“This Moravian nobleman had authority from the then head of the family to remove the tomb of Mircalla, Countess Karnstein, which he did so thoroughly that in a little while its site was quite forgotten.”

“Can you point out where it stood?” asked the general, eagerly.

The forester shook his head and smiled. “Not a soul living could tell you that now,” he said. “Besides, they say her body was removed; but no one is sure of that either.”

Having thus spoken, he dropped his axe and departed, leaving us to hear the remainder of the General’s strange story.

18 The undead.

19 A historical country that occupied what is now the easternmost portion of the Czech Republic.

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CHAPTER XIV

THE MEETING

“My beloved child,” the general resumed, “was now growing rapidly worse. The physician who attended her had failed to produce the slightest dent against her disease—for, then, I supposed it to be a disease. He saw my alarm and suggested a consultation. I called in an abler physician from Gratz. Several days elapsed before he arrived. He was a good and pious as well as a learned man. Having seen my poor ward together, the doctors withdrew to my library to confer and discuss.

I, from the adjoining room where I awaited their summons, heard these two gentlemen’s voices raised in something sharper than a strictly philosophical discussion. I knocked at the door and entered. I found the old physician from Gratz maintaining his theory. His rival was combating it with undisguised ridicule, accompanied with bursts of laughter. This unseemly manifestation subsided and the altercation ended on my entrance.

“‘Sir,’ said the first physician, ‘my learned brother seems to think that you want a conjuror and not a doctor.’

“‘Pardon me,’ said the old physician from Gratz, looking displeased, ‘I shall state my own view of the case in my own way another time. I grieve, Monsieur le General, that by my skill and science I can be of no use. But before I go I shall do myself the honor to suggest something to you.’

“He seemed thoughtful and sat down at a table and began to write. Profoundly disappointed, I made my bow, and as I turned to go, the other doctor pointed over his shoulder to his companion who was writing and then, with a shrug, touched his forehead as if to signify madness.

“This consultation, then, left me precisely where I was. I walked out into the grounds, all but distracted. The doctor from Gratz, in ten or fifteen minutes, overtook me. He apologized for having followed me but said that he could not conscientiously take his leave without a few words more. He told me that he could not be mistaken; no natural disease exhibited the same symptoms; death was already very near. There remained, however, a day, possibly two, of life. If the fatal seizure were at once arrested, with great care and skill her strength might possibly return. But all hung now upon the confines of the irrevocable. One more assault might extinguish the last spark of vitality which is, every moment, ready to die.

“‘And what is the nature of the seizure you speak of?’ I entreated.

“‘I have stated all fully in this note, which I place in your hands upon the distinct condition that you send for the nearest clergyman and open my letter in his presence, and on no account read it until he is with you; you would not listen otherwise, and it is a matter of life and death. Should the priest fail you, then, indeed, you may read it.’

“He asked me, before finally taking his leave, whether I would wish to see a man curiously learned upon the very subject which, after I had read his letter, would probably interest me above all others. He urged me earnestly to invite him there and then departed.

“The clergyman was absent, so I read the letter by myself. At another time, or in another case, it might have provoked my ridicule. But into what quackeries will not people rush for a last chance, where all accustomed means have failed, and the life of a loved one is at stake?

“Nothing could have been more absurd than the learned man’s letter. It was monstrous enough to have consigned him to a madhouse. He said that the patient was suffering from the visits of a vampire! The punctures she described as having occurred near the throat were, he insisted, the insertion of those two long, thin, and sharp teeth which—it is well known—are peculiar to vampires; and there could be no doubt, he added, as to the well-defined presence of the small, livid mark which all concurred in describing as that induced by the demon’s lips. Every symptom described by the sufferer was in exact conformity with those recorded in every case of a similar visitation.

“Being myself wholly skeptical as to the existence of any such portent as the vampire, the supernatural theory of the good doctor furnished, in my opinion, but another instance of learning and intelligence being oddly associated with some hallucination or another. I was so miserable, however, that, rather than try nothing, I acted upon the instructions of the letter.

“I concealed myself in the dark dressing room that opened upon the poor patient’s room, in which a candle was burning, and watched there till she was fast asleep. I stood at the door, peeping through the small crevice with my sword laid on the table beside me, as my directions prescribed, until at a little after one o’clock I saw a large black object, very ill-defined, crawl over the foot of the bed and swiftly spread itself up to the poor girl’s throat, where it swelled into a great, palpitating mass.

“For a few moments I stood petrified. I then sprang forward with my sword in my hand. The black creature suddenly contracted towards the foot of the bed and glided over it. Then, standing on the floor with a glare of skulking ferocity and horror fixed on me, I saw Millarca. Speculating I know not what, I struck at her instantly with my sword; but then I saw her standing near the door, unscathed. Horrified, I pursued and struck again. She was gone; my sword struck the door.

“I can’t describe to you all that passed on that horrible night. The whole house was up and stirring. The specter Millarca was gone. But her victim was declining quickly, and before the morning dawned, she died.”

The old general was agitated. We did not speak to him. My father walked a little distance and began reading the inscriptions on the tombstones; thus occupied, he strolled into the door of a side chapel to pursue his research. The general leaned against the wall, dried his eyes, and sighed heavily. His eyes were fixed on the ground as he leaned with his hand upon the basement of a shattered monument.

Having just listened to so strange a story in this solitude—connected, as it was, with the great and titled dead whose monuments moldered among the dust and ivy round us—and with every incident that matched my own mysterious case, a horror had begun to steal over me. I heard the voices of Carmilla and Madame, who were at that moment approaching. In this haunted spot, darkened by the towering foliage that rose on every side, dense and high above its noiseless walls, my heart sank as I thought that my friends were about to enter and disturb this sorrowful and ominous scene.

Under a narrow, arched doorway, surmounted by one of those demoniacal grotesques in which the cynical and ghastly fancy of old Gothic carving delights, I saw the beautiful face and figure of Carmilla enter the shadowy chapel.

I was just about to rise and speak in answer to her peculiarly engaging smile when, with a cry, the old man by my side caught up the woodman’s hatchet and started forward. On seeing him a brutal change came over her features. It was an instantaneous and horrible transformation; she made a crouching step backwards. Before I could utter a scream, he struck at her with all his force. She dove under his blow and, unscathed, caught him by the wrist in her tiny grasp. He struggled for a moment to release his arm, but his hand opened, the axe fell to the ground, and the girl was gone.

The general staggered against the wall. His grey hair stood upon his head, and a moisture shone over his face as if he were at the point of death.

The frightful scene had passed in a moment. The first thing I recollect afterward is Madame standing before me, impatiently repeating, again and again, "Where is Mademoiselle Carmilla?"

I answered at length, "I don't know—I can't tell—she went there." I pointed to the door through which Madame had just entered. "Only a minute or two since."

"But I have been standing there, in the passage, ever since Mademoiselle Carmilla entered, and she did not return."

She then began to call, "Carmilla!" through every door and passage and from the windows. No answer came.

"She called herself Carmilla?" asked the general, still agitated.

"Carmilla, yes," I answered.

"Aye," he said, "that is Millarca. That is the same person who long ago was called Mircalla, Countess Karnstein. Depart from this accursed ground, my poor child, as quickly as you can. Drive to the clergyman's house and stay there till we come. Begone! May you never behold Carmilla more; you will not find her here."

CHAPTER XV

ORDEAL AND EXECUTION

As he spoke, one of the strangest-looking men I ever beheld entered the chapel at the door through which Carmilla had made her entrance and her exit. He was tall, narrow-chested, and stooping, with high shoulders, and was dressed in black. His face was brown and dried in with deep furrows; he wore an oddly shaped hat with a broad leaf. His hair, long and grizzled, hung on his shoulders. He wore a pair of gold spectacles and walked slowly, with an odd shambling gait, his face sometimes turned up to the sky and sometimes bowed down towards the ground. He seemed to wear a perpetual smile; his long, thin arms were swinging, and his lank hands, in old black gloves ever so much too wide for them, waving and gesticulating in utter abstraction.

“The very man!” exclaimed the general, advancing with palpable delight. “My dear Baron, how happy I am to see you; I had no hope of meeting you so soon.” He signaled to my father, who had by this time returned, and led the fantastic old gentleman to meet him. He introduced him formally, and they at once entered into earnest conversation.

The stranger took a roll of paper from his pocket and spread it on the worn surface of a tomb that stood by. He had a pencil case in his fingers, with which he traced imaginary lines from point to point on the paper. This paper, from the way they all glanced back and forth from it to certain points of the building, I concluded to be a plan of the

chapel. He accompanied his lecture with occasional readings from a dirty little book, whose yellow pages were crowded with script.

They sauntered together down the side aisle, opposite to the spot where I was standing, conversing as they went; then they begun measuring distances by paces, and finally they all stood together, facing a piece of the sidewall, which they began to examine with great minuteness. They pulled off the ivy that clung over it and rapped the plaster with the ends of their sticks, scraping here and knocking there. At length they ascertained the existence of a broad marble tablet, with letters carved in relief upon it.

With the assistance of the woodman, who soon returned, they uncovered an inscription and a carved coat of arms. They proved to be those of the long-lost monument of Mircalla, Countess Karnstein.

The old general, though not given to the praying mood, raised his hands and eyes to heaven in mute thanksgiving.

“Tomorrow,” I heard him say, “the commissioner will be here, and the inquisition will be held according to law.”

Then, turning to the old man with the gold spectacles, he shook him warmly by both hands and said: “Baron, how can I thank you? How can we all thank you? You will have delivered this region from a plague that has scourged its inhabitants for more than a century. The horrible enemy, thank God, is at last tracked.”

My father led the stranger aside, and the general followed. I knew that he had led them out of hearing that he might relate my case to them, and I saw them glance often quickly at me as the discussion proceeded.

My father came to me, kissed me again and again, and, leading me from the chapel, said: “It is time to return. But before we go home, we must add to our party the good priest, who lives but a little way from this, and persuade him to accompany us to the manor-house.”

In this quest we were successful: and I was glad, being unspeakably fatigued when we reached home.

But my satisfaction changed to dismay when I discovered that there were no tidings of Carmilla. Of the scene that had occurred in the ruined chapel, no explanation was offered to me, and it was clear that it was a secret which my father for the present was determined to keep from me.

The sinister absence of Carmilla made the scene even more horrible. The arrangements for the night were singular: Two servants and Madame were to sit up in my room that night, and the priest, with my father, kept watch in the adjoining dressing room.

The priest had performed certain solemn rites that night, the purport of which I did not understand any more than I comprehended the reason of this extraordinary precaution taken for my safety during sleep.

I saw all clearly a few days later. The disappearance of Carmilla was followed by the discontinuance of my nightly sufferings.

You have heard, no doubt, of the appalling superstition that prevails in Upper and Lower Styria, in Moravia, Silesia, ²⁰ in Turkish Serbia, in Poland, even in Russia: the superstition, for so we must call it, of the Vampire.

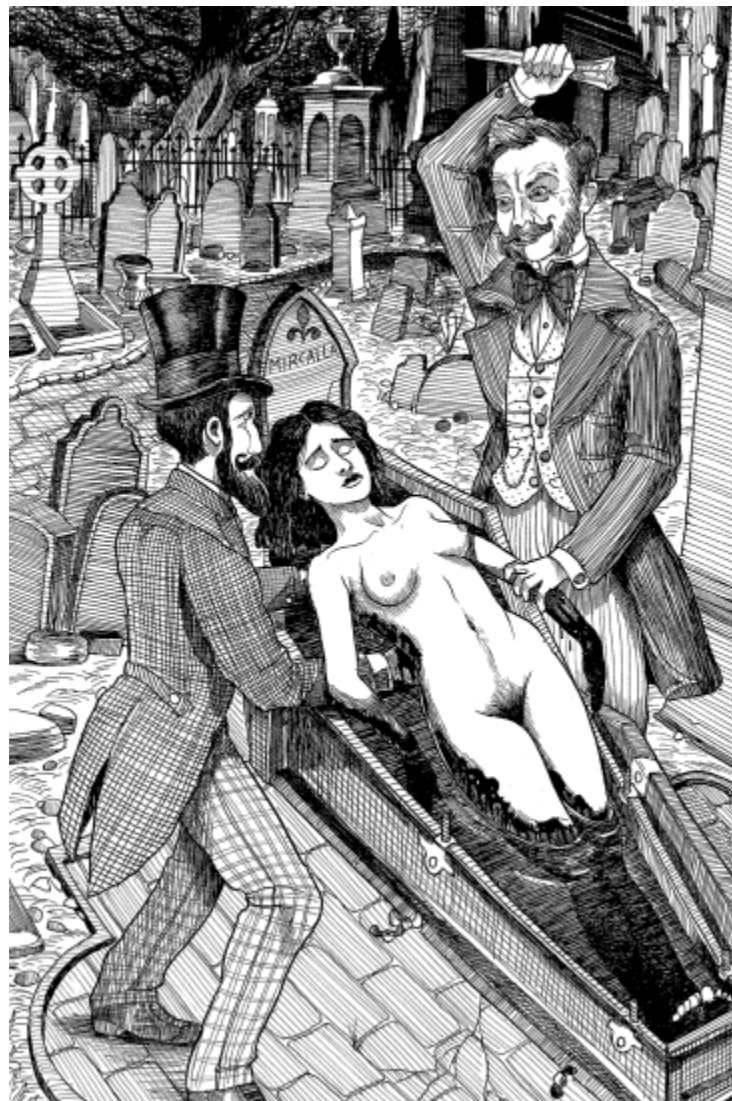
If human testimony—taken with every care and solemnity, judicially and before commissions innumerable, each consisting of many members all chosen for their integrity and intelligence, and constituting reports more voluminous than perhaps exist regarding any other class of cases—is worth anything, it is difficult to deny or even to doubt the existence of the phenomenon of the Vampire.

For my part I have heard no theory by which to explain what I myself have witnessed and experienced, other than that supplied by the ancient and well-attested belief of the country.

The next day, the formal proceedings took place in the Chapel of Karnstein. The grave of the Countess Mircalla was opened, and the

general and my father recognized each his perfidious and beautiful guest in the face now disclosed to view.

Her features, though a hundred and fifty years had passed since her funeral, were tinted with the warmth of life. Her eyes were open; no cadaverous smell exhaled from the coffin. The two medical men—one officially present, the other on the part of the promoter of the inquiry—attested to the marvelous fact that there was a faint but appreciable respiration and a corresponding action of the heart. The limbs were perfectly flexible, the flesh elastic, and the leaden coffin filled with blood to a depth of seven inches, in which the body lay immersed.



Here then, were all the admitted signs and proofs of vampirism. The body, therefore, in accordance with the ancient practice, was raised, and a sharp stake driven through the heart of the vampire. It uttered a piercing shriek at that moment, in all respects such as might escape from a living person in the last agony. Then the head was struck off, and a torrent of blood flowed from the severed neck. The body and head were next placed on a pile of wood and reduced to ashes, which were thrown upon the river and borne away, and that territory has never since been plagued by the visits of a vampire.

My father has a copy of the report of the imperial commission, with the signatures of all who were present at these proceedings, attached in verification of the statement. It is from this official paper that I have summarized my account of this last shocking scene.

²⁰ A region of central Europe that shares land with contemporary Poland, Germany, and the Czech Republic.

CHAPTER XVI

CONCLUSION

I write all this, you suppose, with composure. But far from it; I cannot think of it without agitation. Nothing but your earnest desire so repeatedly expressed could have induced me to sit down to a task that has unstrung my nerves and reintroduced the shadow of that unspeakable horror, which for years after my deliverance continued to make my days and nights dreadful, and solitude unmanageably terrifying.

Let me add a word or two about the quaint Baron Vordenburg, to whose curious lore we were indebted for the discovery of the Countess Mircalla's grave.

He had taken up his abode in Gratz, where, living upon a mere pittance—all that remained to him of the once princely estates of his family in Upper Styria—he devoted himself to the minute and laborious investigation of the marvelously authenticated tradition of vampirism. He had at his fingers' ends all the great and little works upon the subject: *Magia Posthuma* , *Phlegon de Mirabilibus* , *Augustinus de Curâ pro Mortuis* , *Philosophicæ et Christianæ Cogitationes de Vampiris* by John Christofer Herenberg, and a thousand others, among which I remember only a few of those he lent to my father. He had a voluminous digest of all the judicial cases, from which he had extracted a system of principles that appear to govern—

some always, and others occasionally only—the condition of the vampire.

You see, the deadly pallor attributed to that sort of revenant is a mere melodramatic fiction. They present, in the grave and when they show themselves in human society, the appearance of healthy life. When disclosed to light in their coffins, they exhibit all the symptoms that are enumerated as those which proved the vampire-life of the long-dead Countess Karnstein.

How they escape from their graves and return to them for certain hours every day, without displacing the clay or leaving any trace of disturbance in the state of the coffin or the cerements, has always been utterly inexplicable. The amphibious existence of the vampire is sustained by daily renewed slumber in the grave. Its horrible lust for living blood supplies the vigor of its waking existence.

The vampire is prone to be fascinated with an engrossing vehemence, resembling the passion of love, by particular persons. In pursuit of these it will exercise inexhaustible patience and stratagem, for access to a particular object may be obstructed in a hundred ways. It will never desist until it has satiated its passion and drained the very life of its coveted victim. But it will, in these cases, husband and protract its murderous enjoyment with the refinement of a connoisseur, and heighten it by the gradual approaches of an artful courtship. In these cases, it seems to yearn for something like sympathy and consent. In ordinary ones, it goes direct to its object, overpowers them with violence, and strangles and exhausts in a single feast.

The vampire is subject, in certain situations, to special conditions. In this particular instance, Mircalla seemed to be limited to a name which, if not her real one, reproduced it without the omission or addition of a single letter—that is to say, *anagrammatically*. *Carmilla* did this; so did *Millarca*.

My father related to the Baron Vordenburg, who remained with us for two or three weeks after the expulsion of Carmilla, the story about

the Moravian nobleman and the vampire at Karnstein churchyard, and then he asked the Baron how he had discovered the exact position of the long-concealed tomb of the Countess Mircalla. The Baron's grotesque features puckered up into a mysterious smile; he looked down, still smiling on his worn spectacle case, and fumbled with it. Then, looking up, he said:

"I have many journals and other papers written by that remarkable man; the most curious among them is one treating of the visit of which you speak, to Karnstein. The tradition, of course, discolours and distorts a little. He might have been termed a Moravian nobleman, for he had changed his abode to that territory, and was a noble. But he was, in truth, a native of Upper Styria. It is enough to say that in very early youth he had been a passionate and favored lover of the beautiful Mircalla, Countess Karnstein. Her early death plunged him into inconsolable grief. It is the nature of vampires to increase and multiply, but according to an ascertained and ghostly law.

"Assume, at starting, a territory perfectly free from that pest. How does it begin, and how does it multiply itself? I will tell you. A person, more or less wicked, puts an end to himself. A suicide, under certain circumstances, becomes a vampire. That specter visits living people in their slumbers; they die, and almost invariably, in the grave, they develop into vampires. This happened in the case of the beautiful Mircalla, who was haunted by one of those demons. My ancestor, Vordenburg, whose title I still bear, soon discovered this, and in the course of the studies to which he devoted himself learned a great deal more.

"Among other things, he concluded that suspicion of vampirism would probably fall, sooner or later, upon the dead countess, who in life had been his idol. He conceived a horror, be she what she might, of her remains being profaned by the outrage of a posthumous execution. He has left a curious paper to prove that the vampire, on expulsion from its amphibious existence, is projected into a far more horrible life, and he resolved to save his once beloved Mircalla from this.

“He adopted the stratagem of a journey here, a pretended removal of her remains, and a real obliteration of her monument. When age had stolen upon him and from the vale of years he looked back on the scenes he was leaving, he considered, in a different spirit, what he had done, and a horror took possession of him. He made the tracings and notes which have guided me to the very spot and drew up a confession of the deception that he had practiced. If he had intended any further action in this matter, death prevented him; and the hand of a remote descendant has, too late for many, directed the pursuit to the lair of the beast.”

We talked a little more, and among other things he said was this:

“One sign of the vampire is the power of the hand. The slender hand of Mircalla closed like a vice of steel on the general’s wrist when he raised the hatchet to strike. But its power is not confined to its grasp; it leaves a numbness in the limb it seizes, which is slowly, if ever, recovered from.”

The following spring, my father took me on a tour through Italy. We remained away for more than a year.

It was long before the terror of recent events subsided. And to this hour the image of Carmilla returns to my memory with ambiguous alternations—sometimes the playful, languid, beautiful girl; sometimes the writhing fiend I saw in the ruined church. Sometimes, I start from a reverie, certain I heard the light step of Carmilla at the drawing-room door.

THE END

About the Editor

Carmen Maria Machado's debut short story collection, *Her Body and Other Parties*, was a finalist for the National Book Award, the Kirkus Prize, the *LA Times* Book Prize Art Seidenbaum Award for First Fiction, the World Fantasy Award, the Dylan Thomas Prize, and the PEN/Robert W. Bingham Prize for Debut Fiction, and the winner of the Bard Fiction Prize, the Lambda Literary Award for Lesbian Fiction, the Shirley Jackson Award, and the National Book Critics Circle's John Leonard Prize. In 2018, the *New York Times* listed *Her Body and Other Parties* as a member of "The New Vanguard," one of "15 remarkable books by women that are shaping the way we read and write fiction in the 21st century."

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CARMILLA

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